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(54) **LOAD HANDLING SYSTEM FOR STORAGE RACKING**

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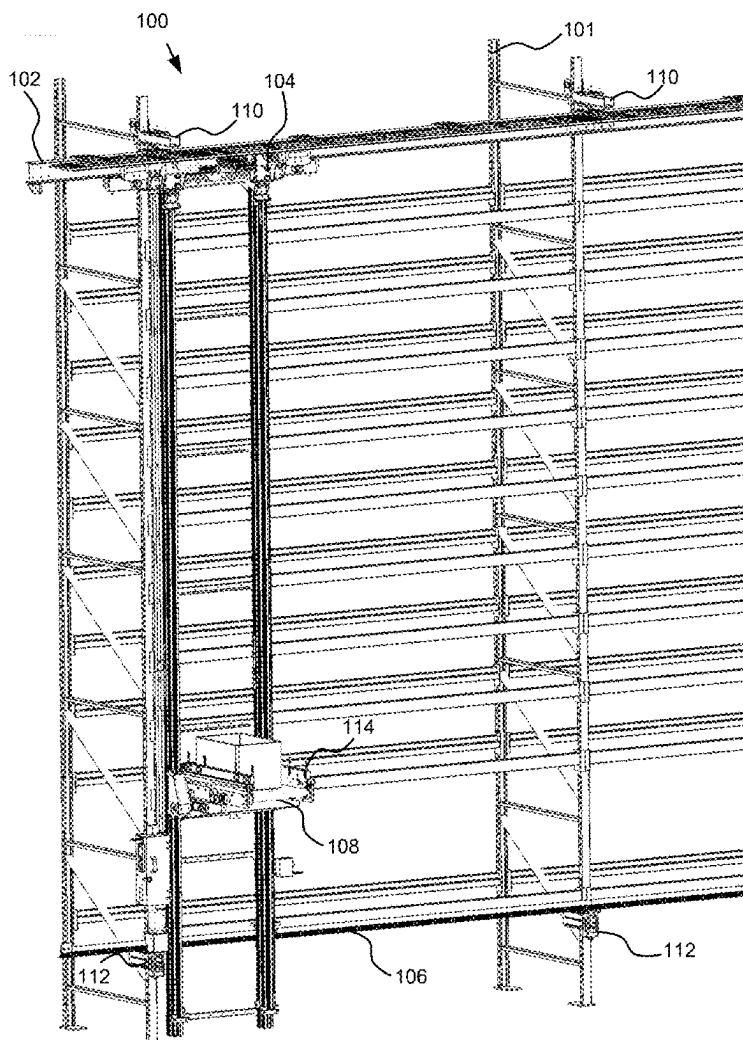
Related U.S. Application Data

(62) Division of application No. 18/917,863, filed on Oct. 16, 2024.

(60) Provisional application No. 63/590,702, filed on Oct. 16, 2023, provisional application No. 63/563,970, filed on Mar. 12, 2024.

(57) **ABSTRACT**

A load handling system for storage racking includes a horizontal guide rail system integrated with the storage racking and a vertical guide rail assembly that moves horizontally along the horizontal guide rail system via a first motor. A load handling platform, coupled to the vertical guide rail assembly, is vertically movable along the assembly by a second motor. The system further comprises a load transition station connected to the storage racking, where a load handling device on the load handling platform transfers loads between the storage racking and the load transition station. Additionally, a ground handling device facilitates the movement of loads between the load transition station and other locations within a storage facility, enhancing the efficiency of load management and distribution.



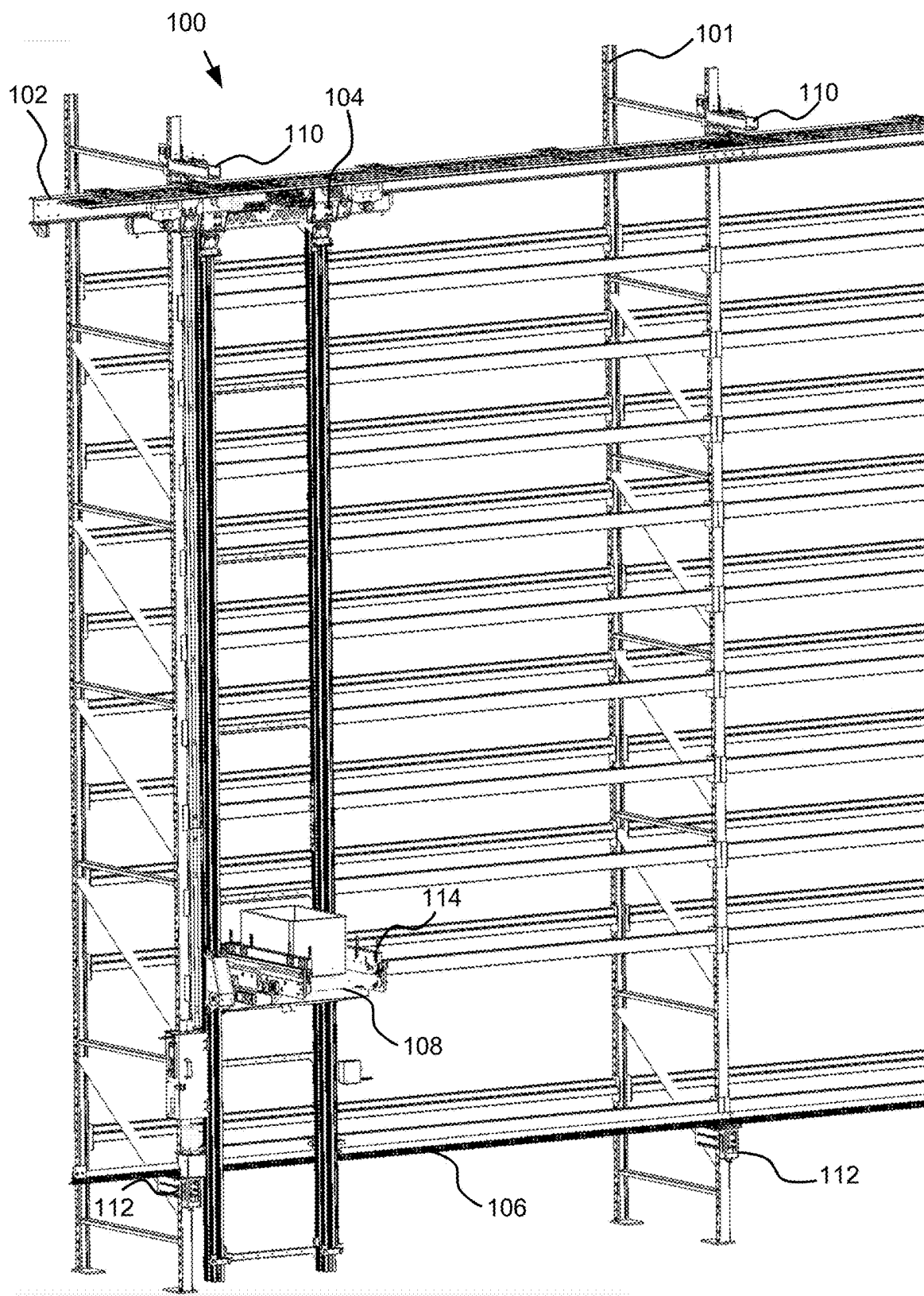


Figure 1

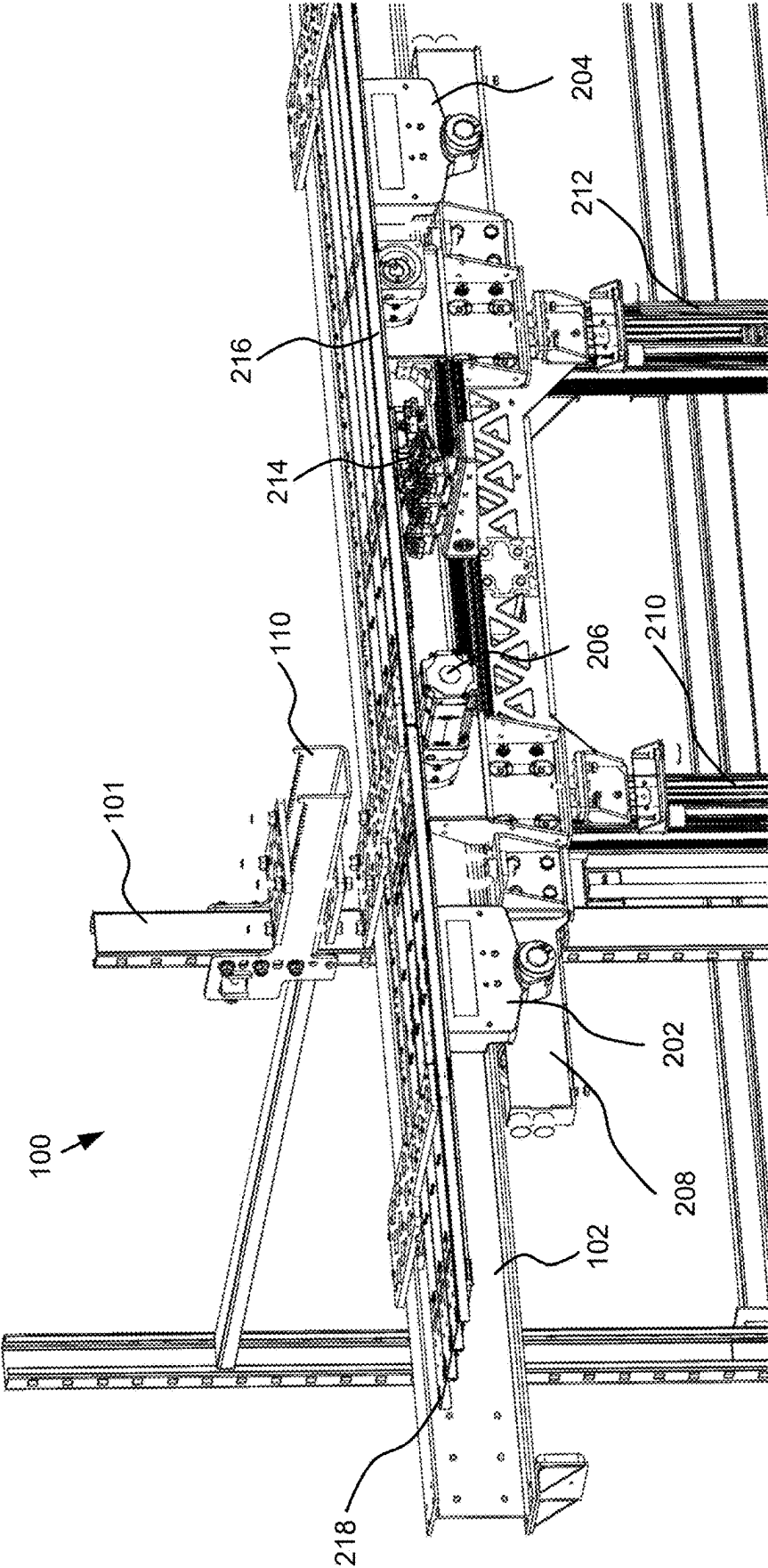


Figure 2

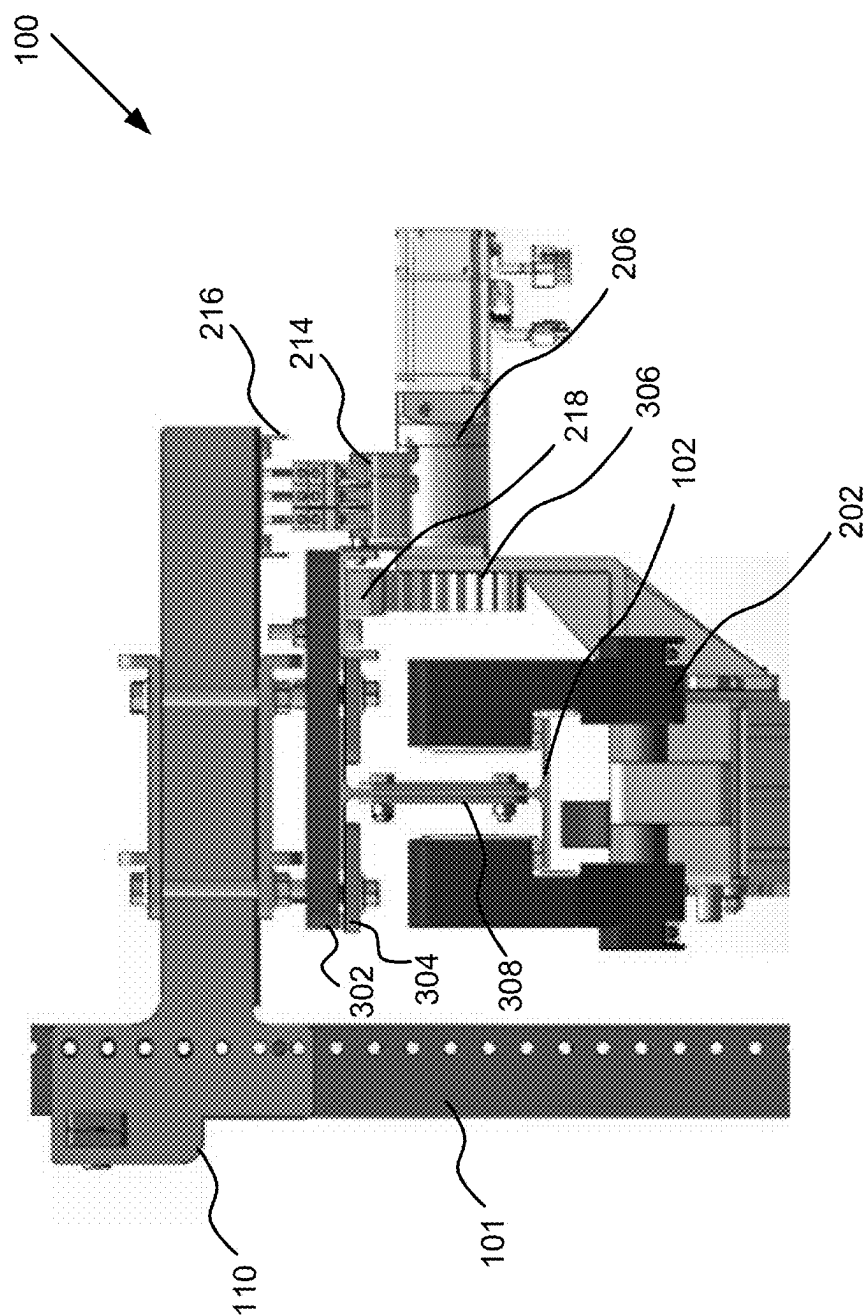


Figure 3

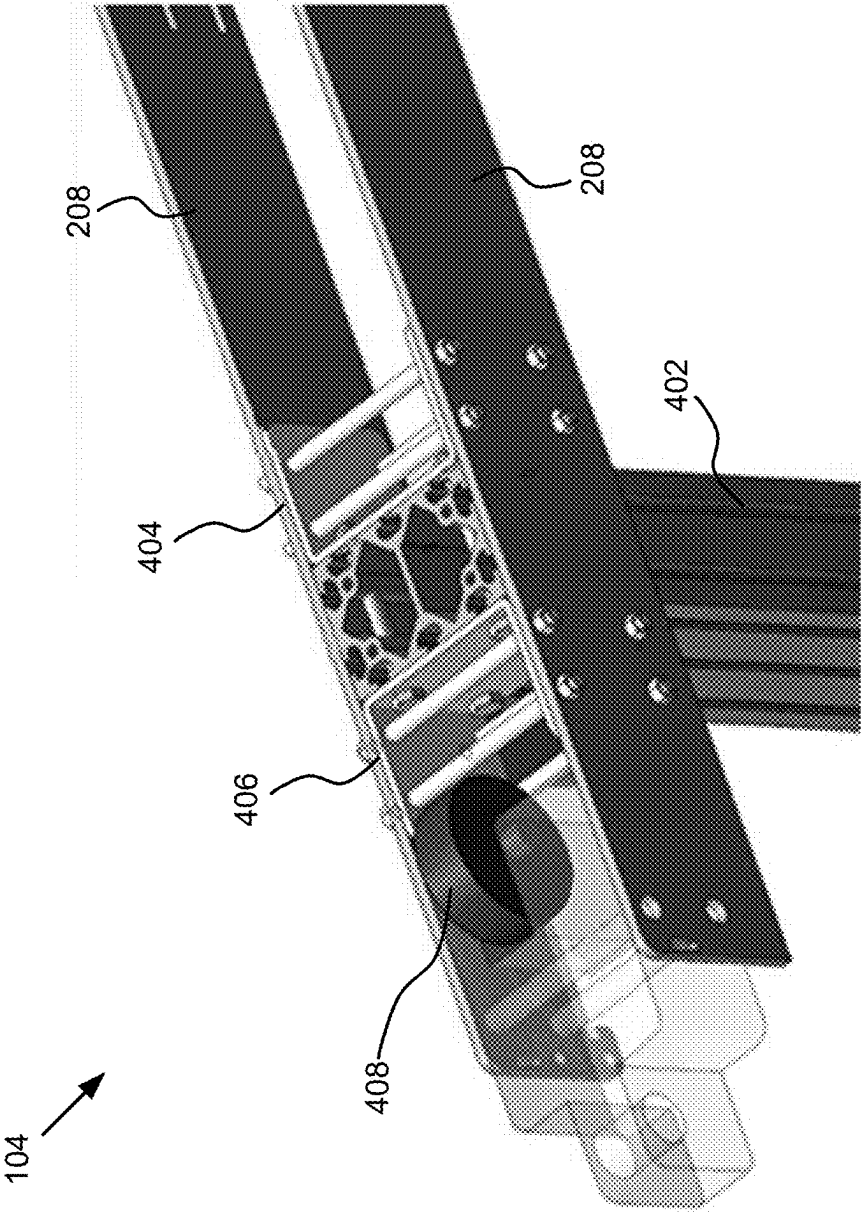


Figure 4

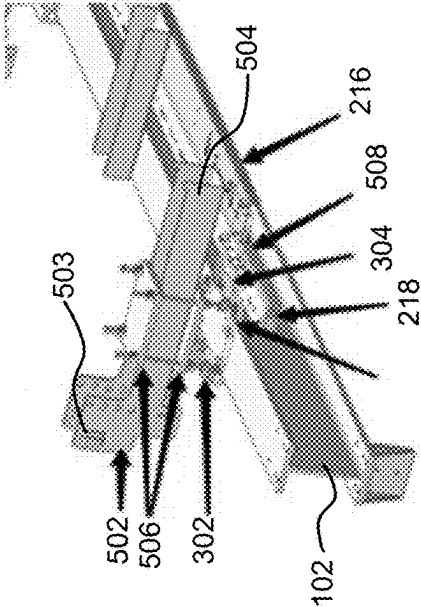


Figure 5

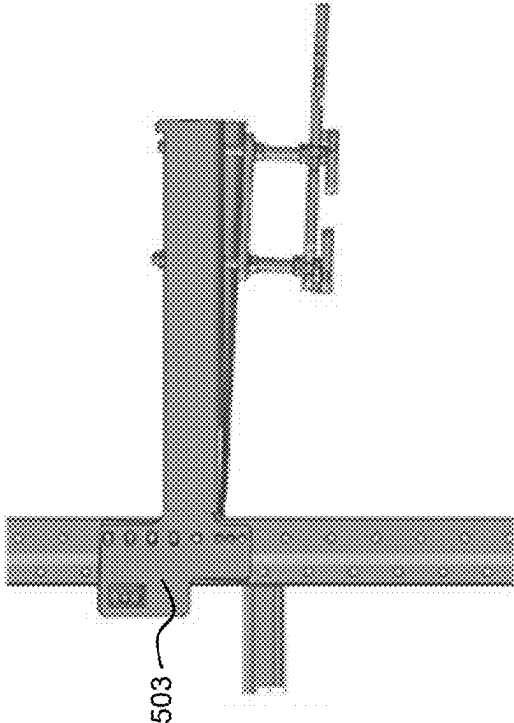


Figure 7

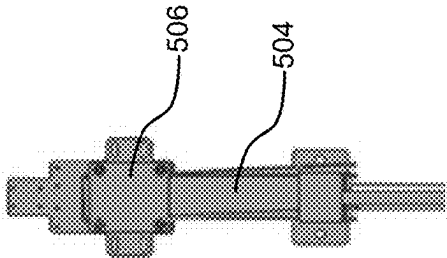


Figure 6

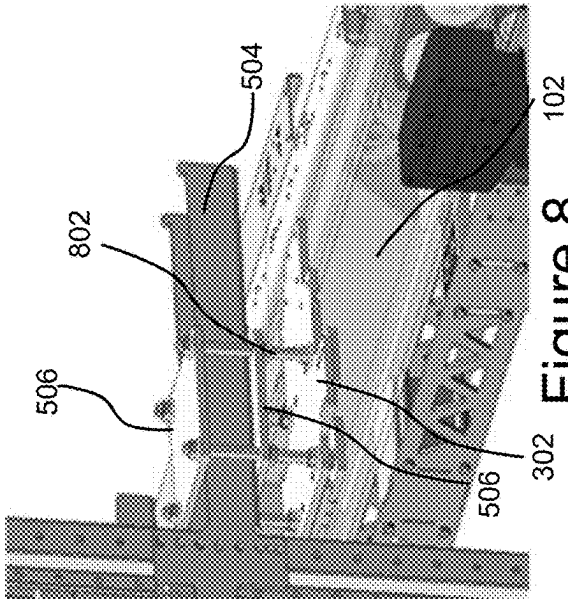


Figure 8

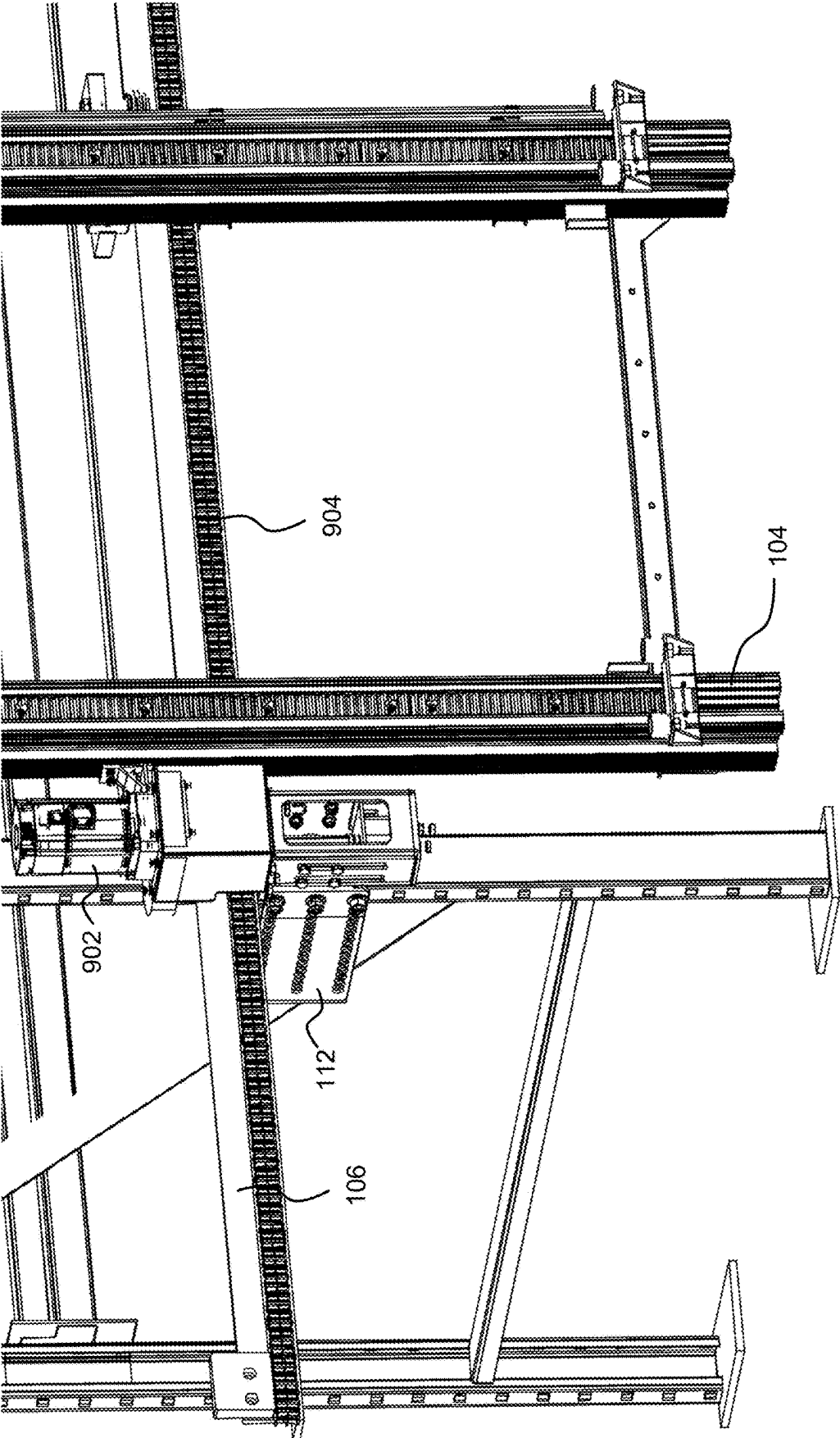


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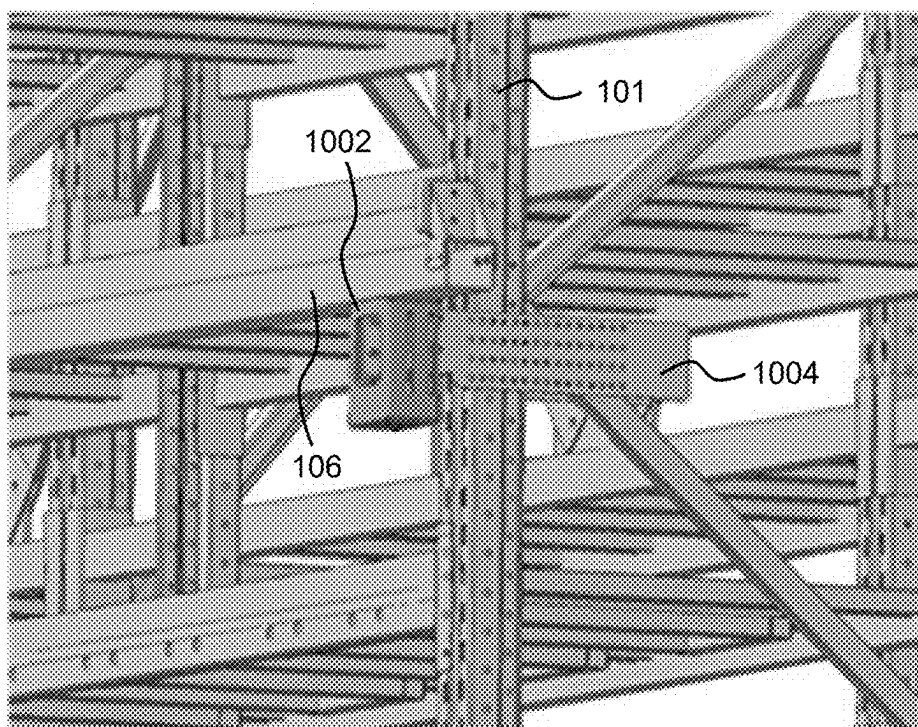


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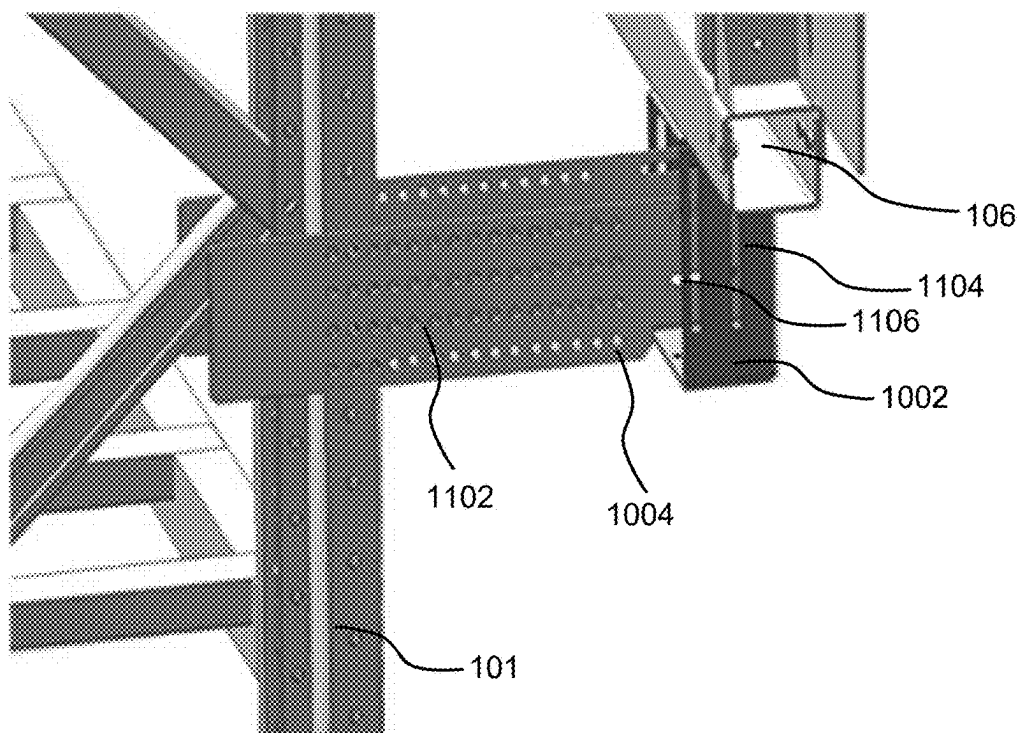


Figure 11

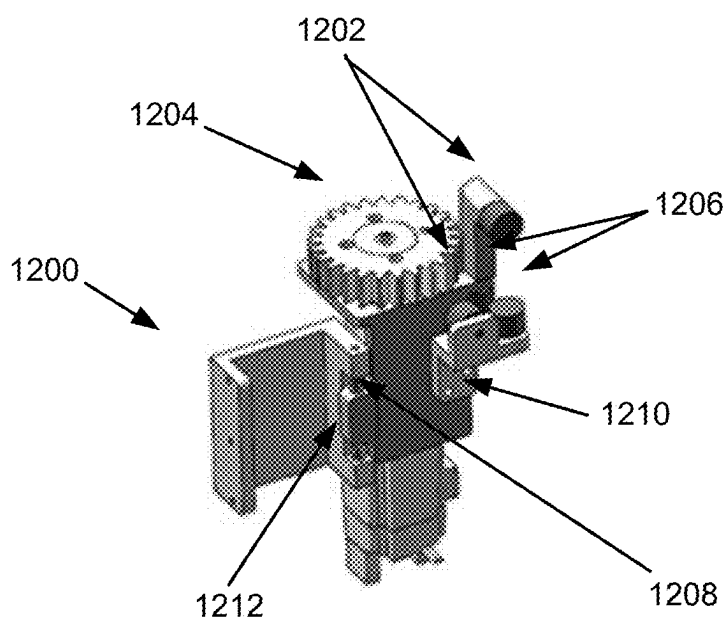


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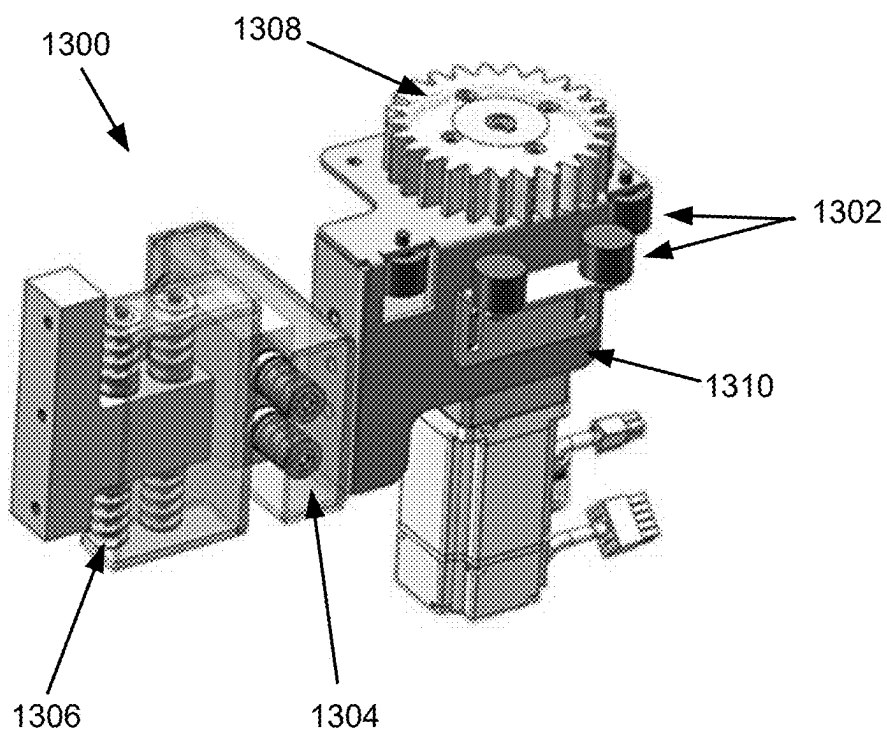


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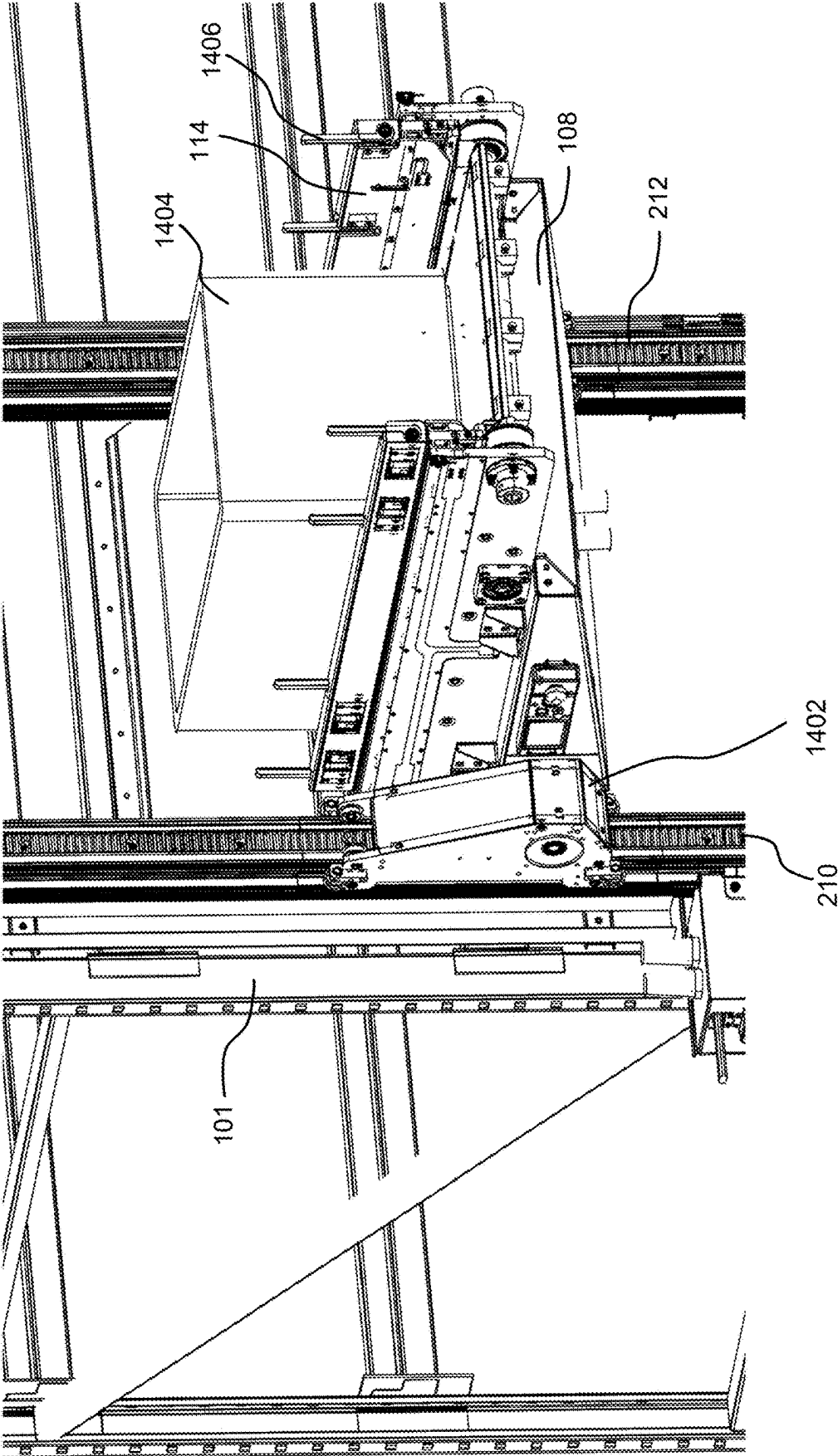


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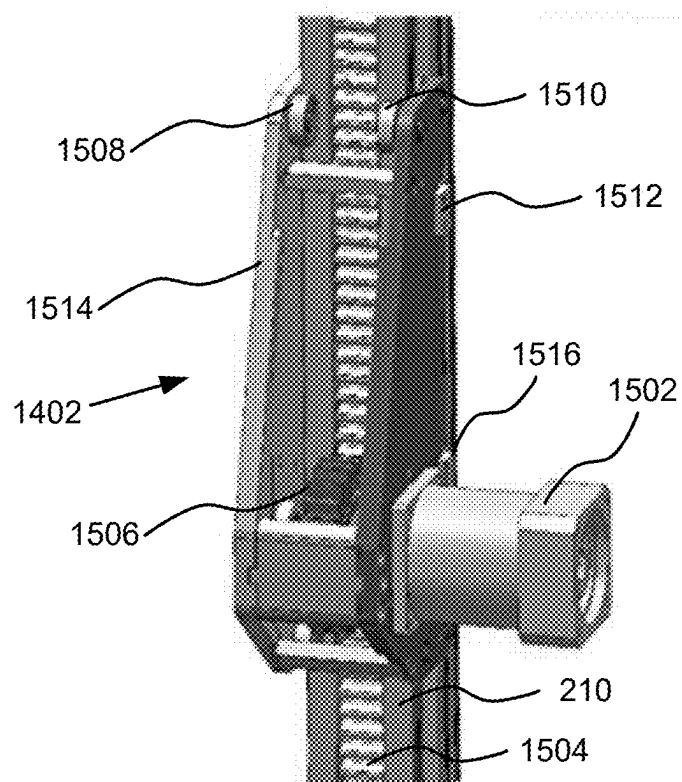


Figure 15

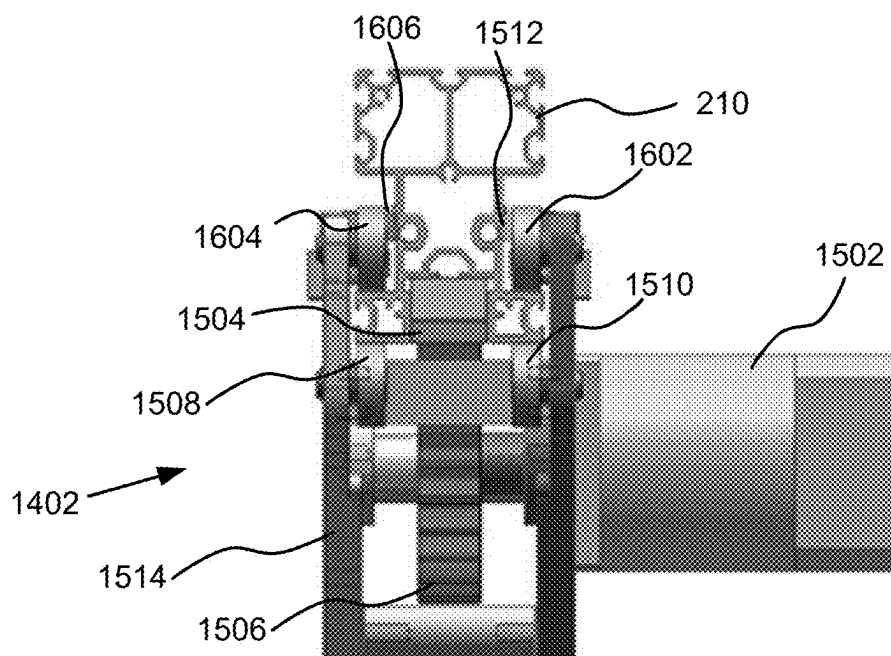


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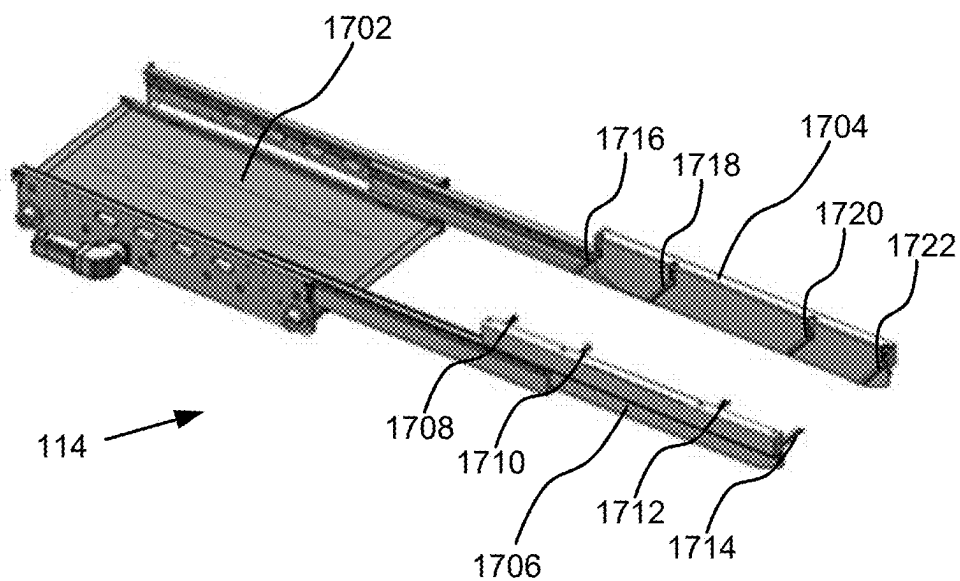


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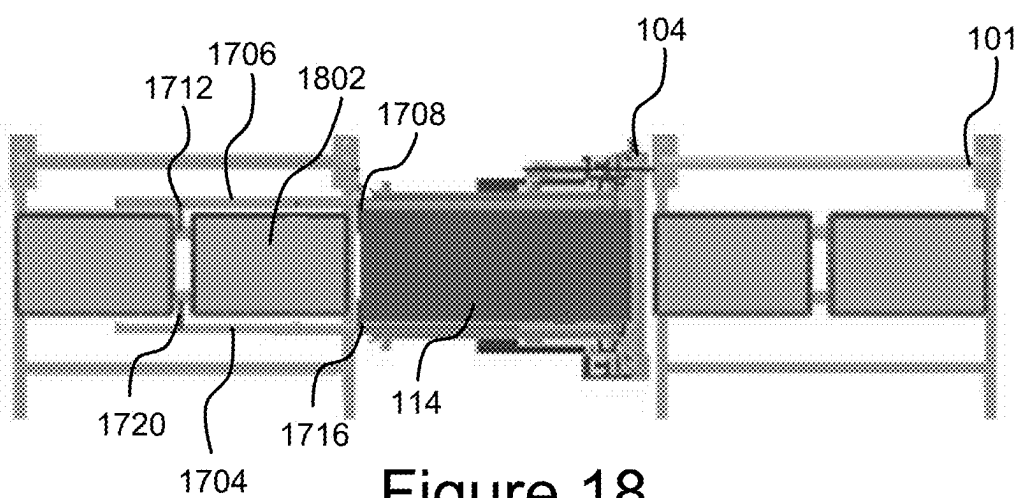


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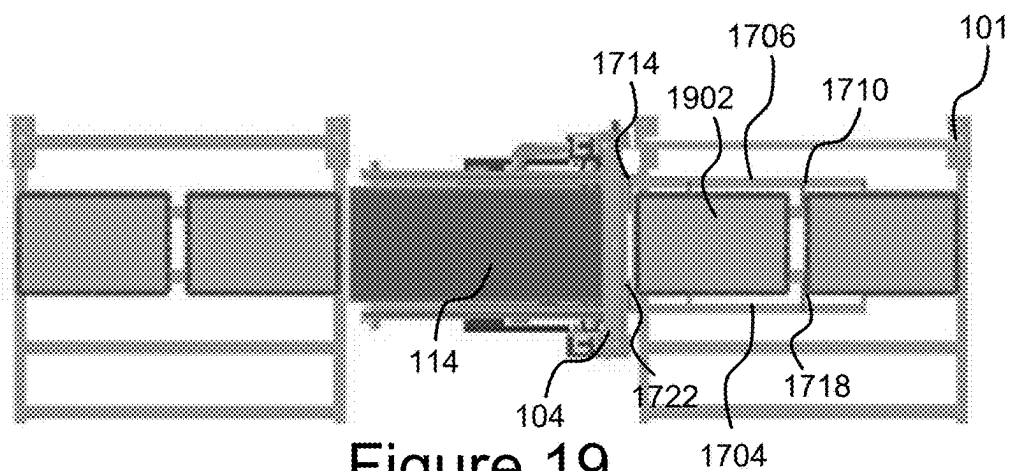


Figure 19

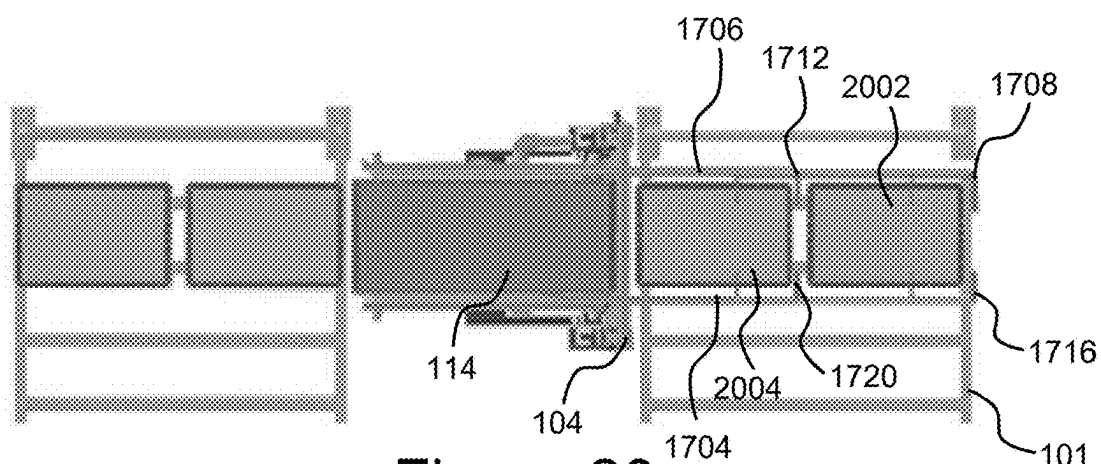


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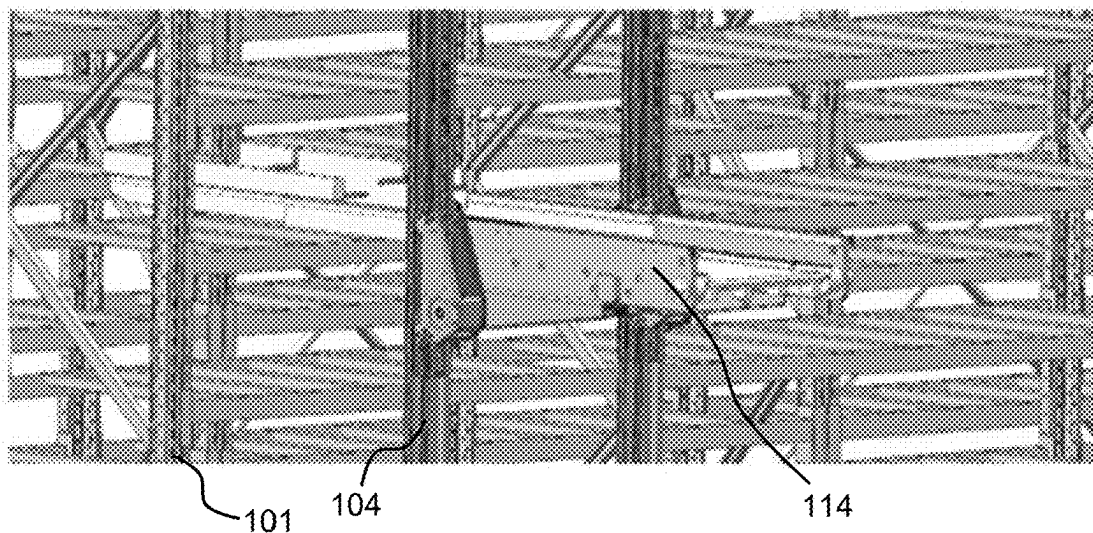


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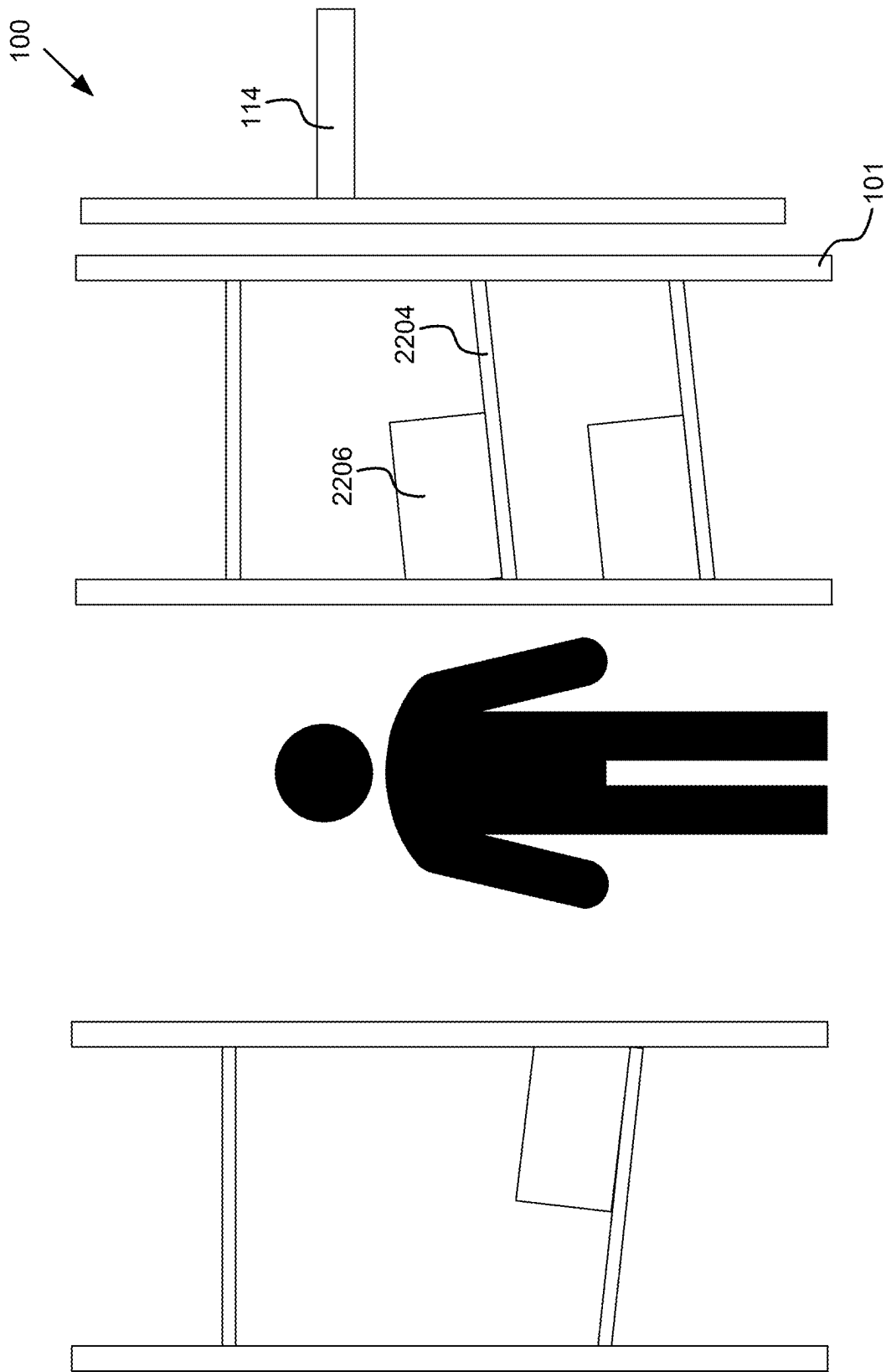


Figure 22

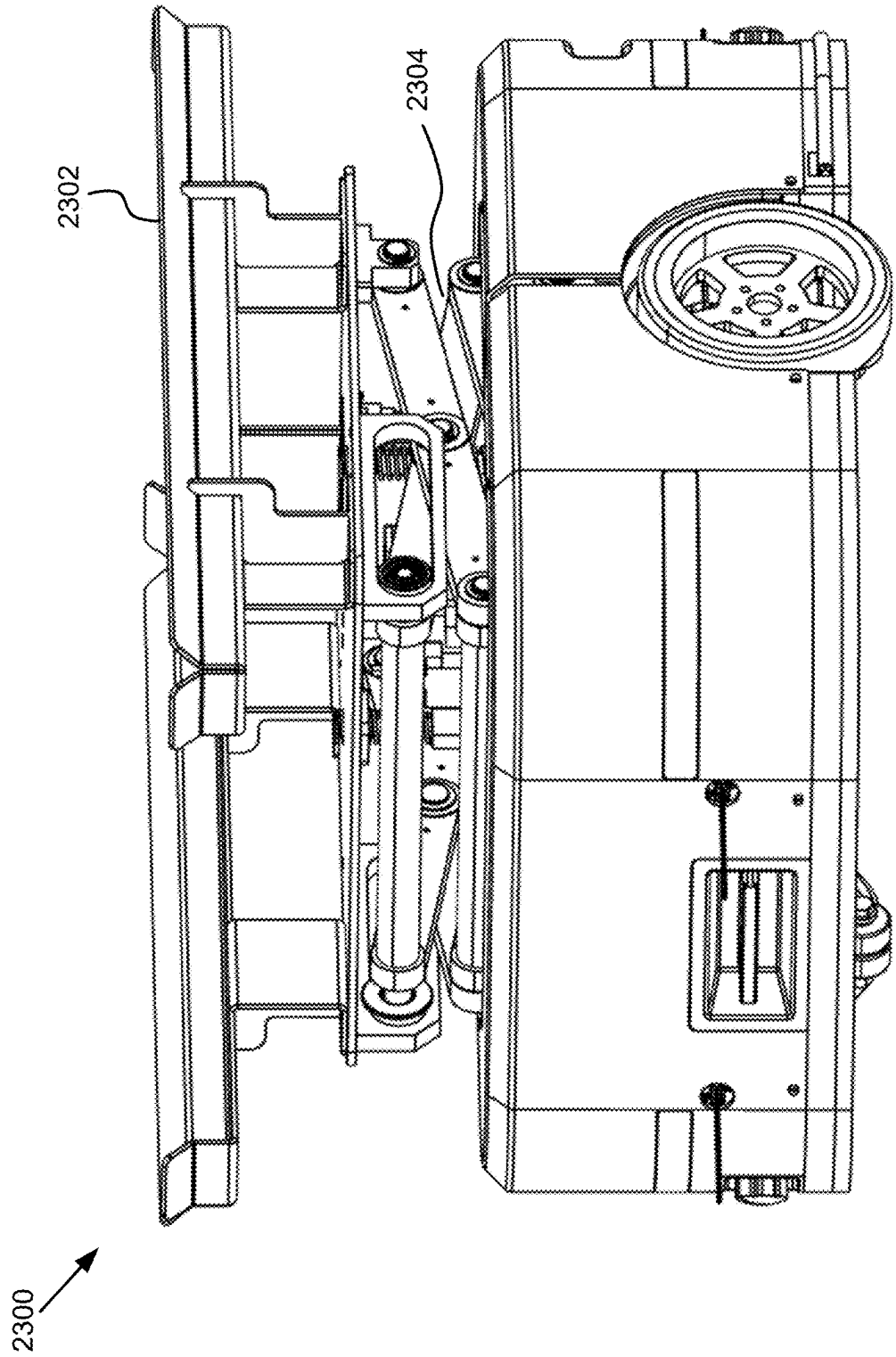


Figure 23

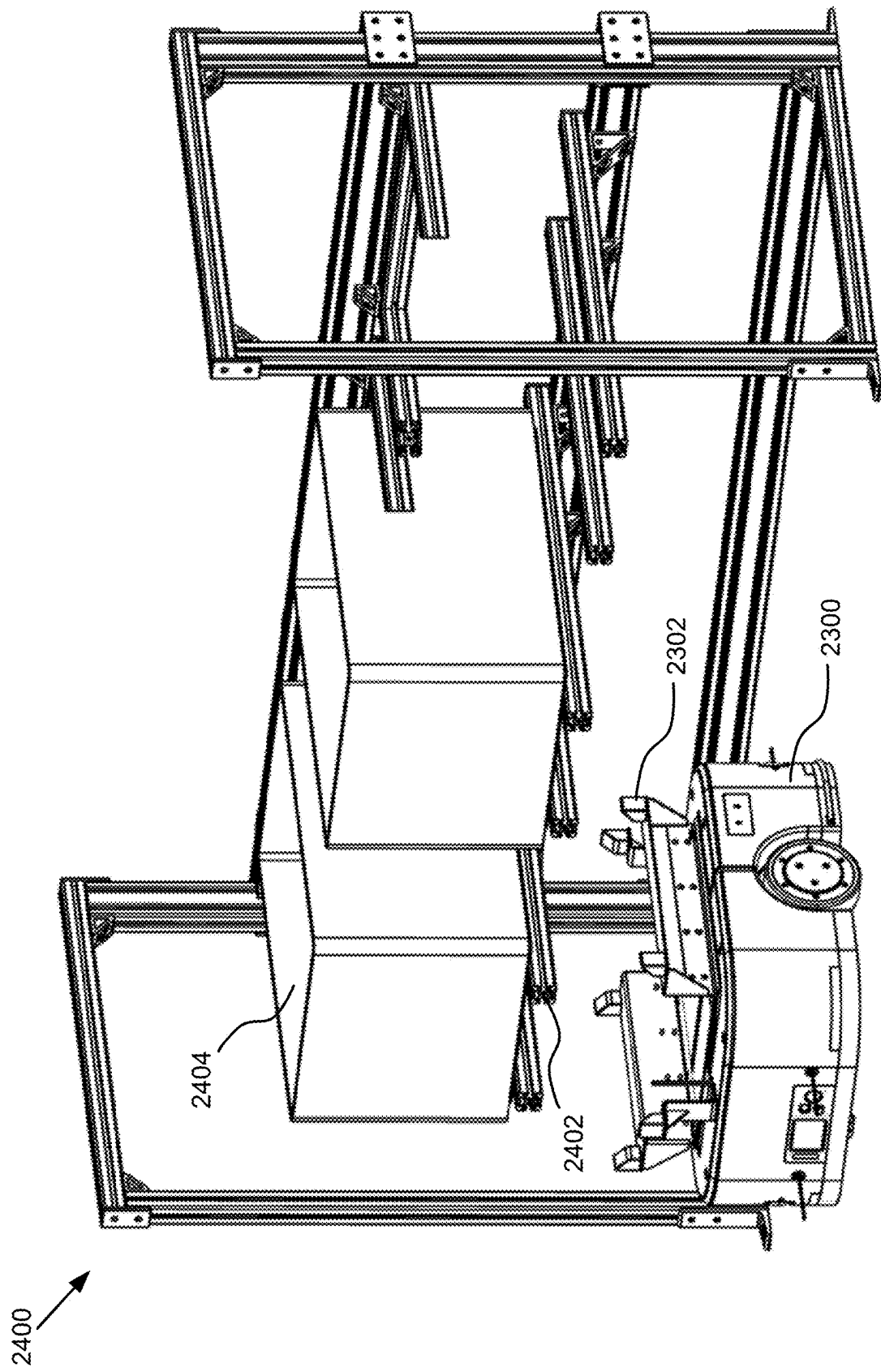


Figure 24

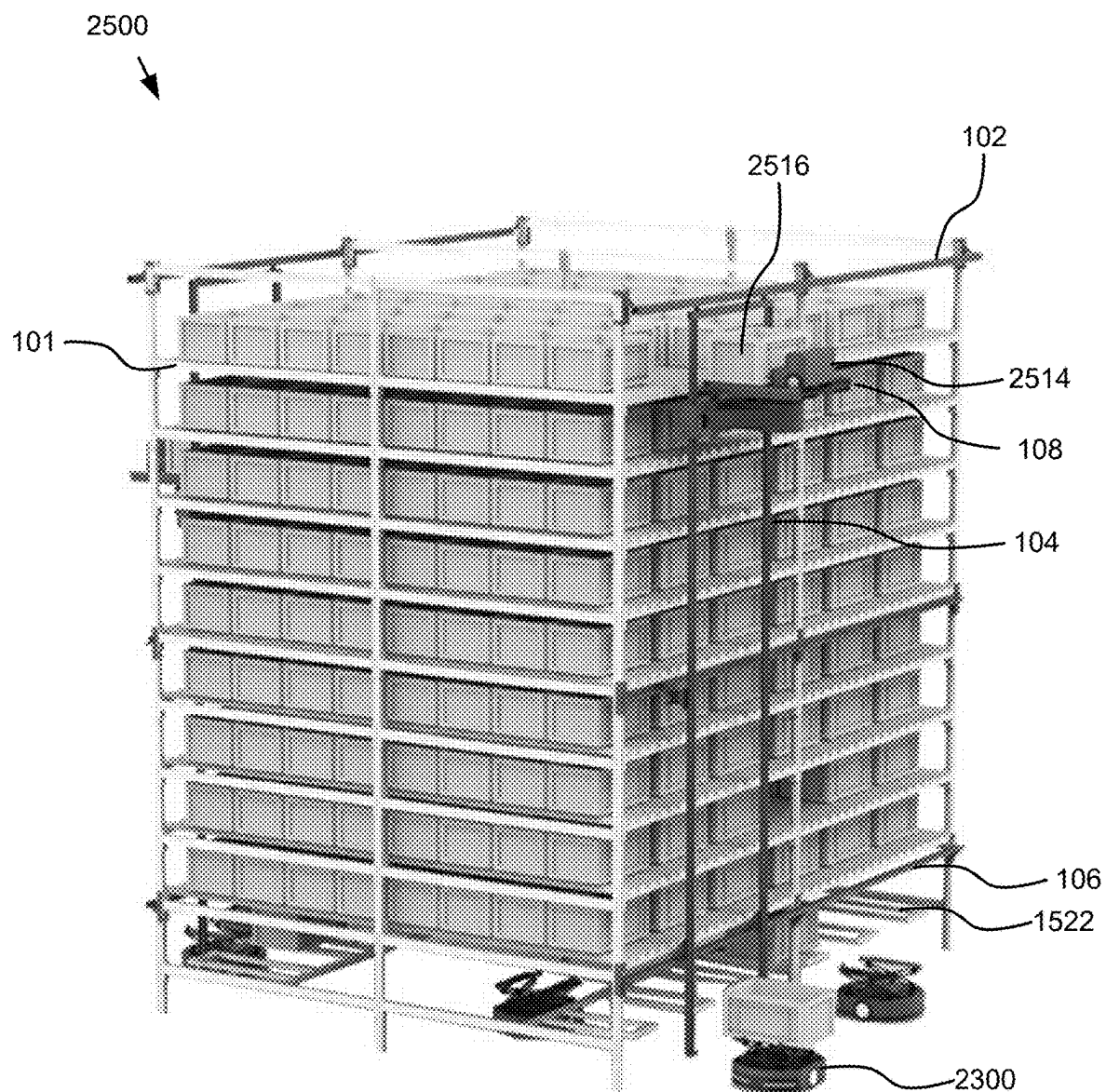


Figure 25

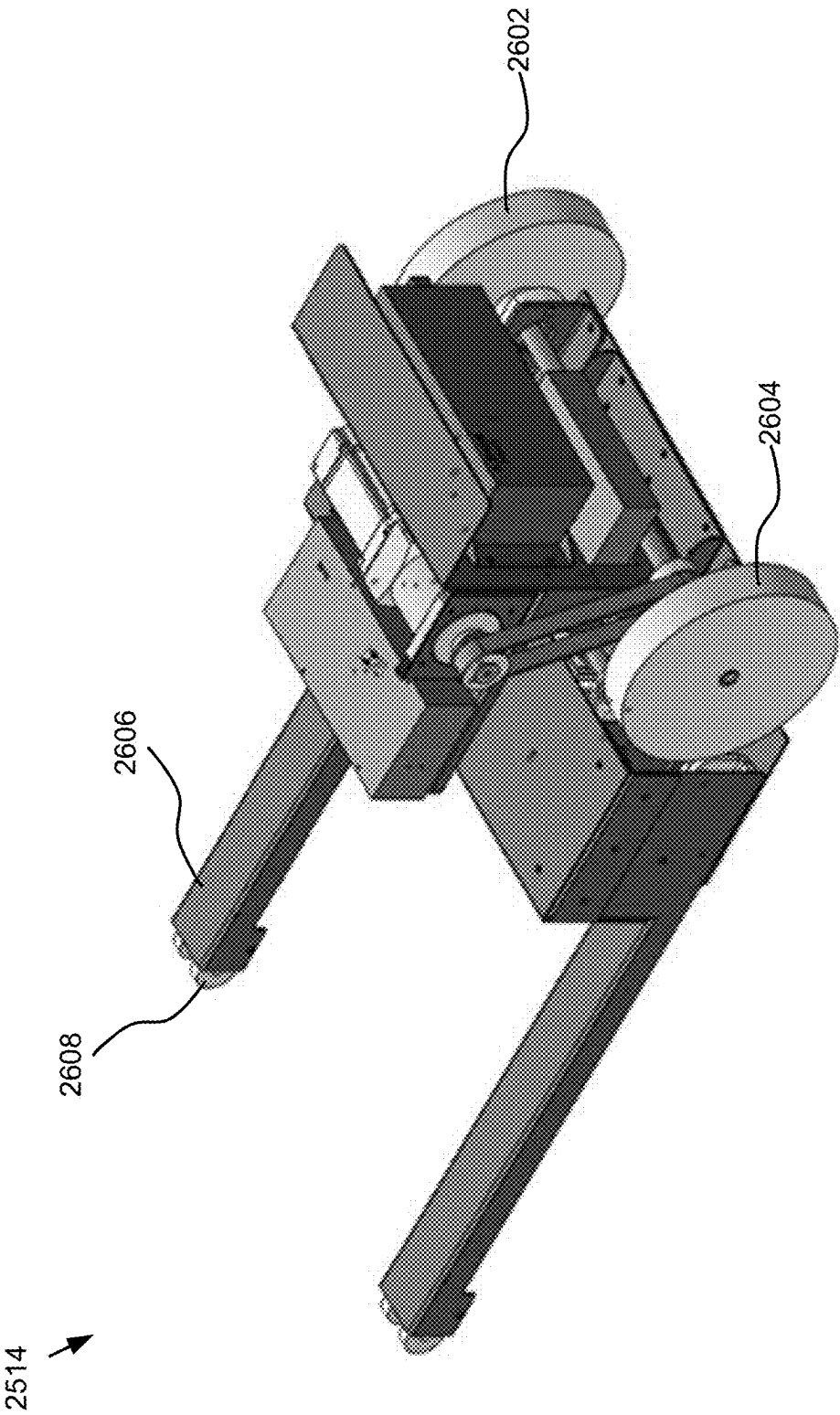


Figure 26

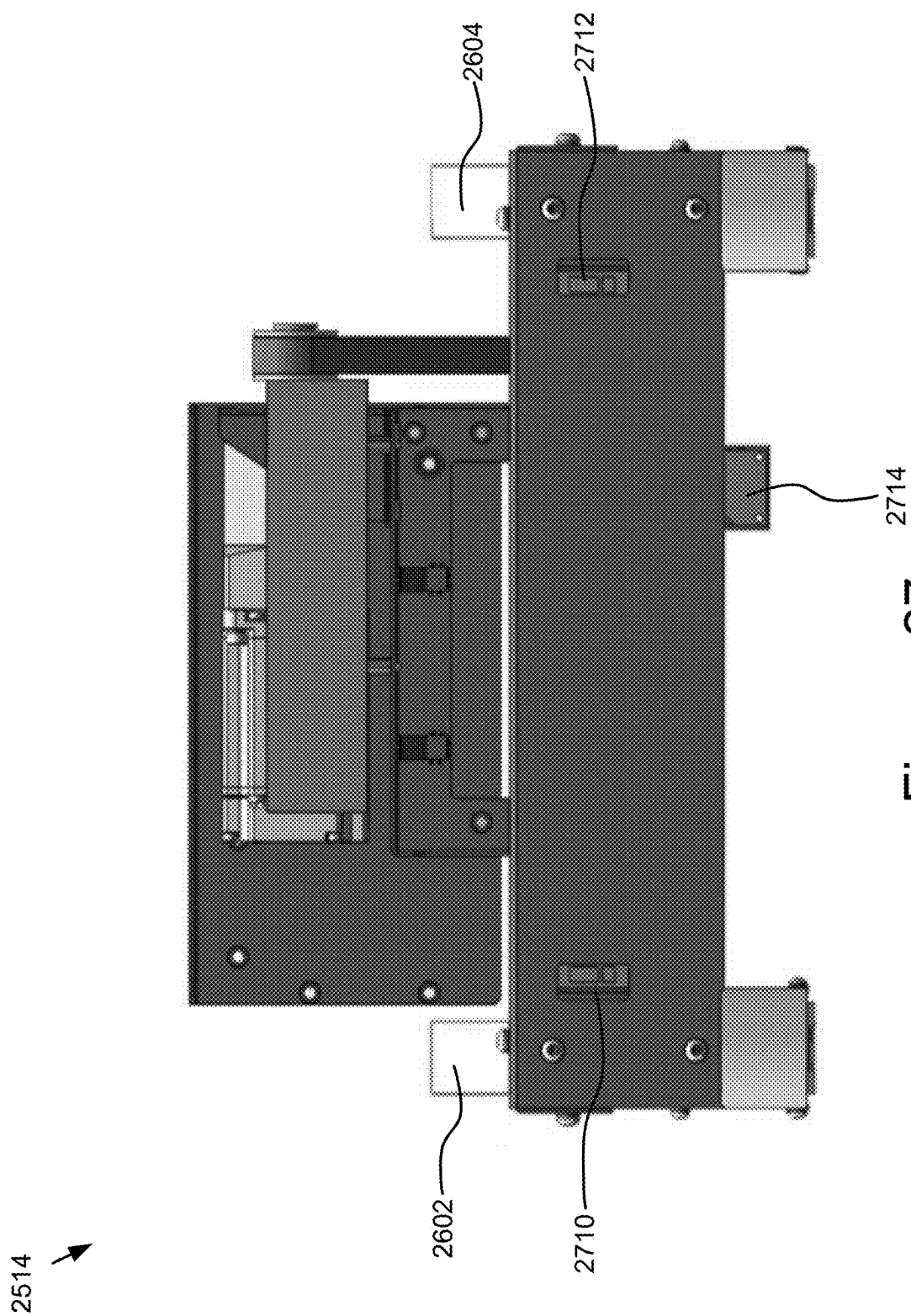


Figure 27

2514

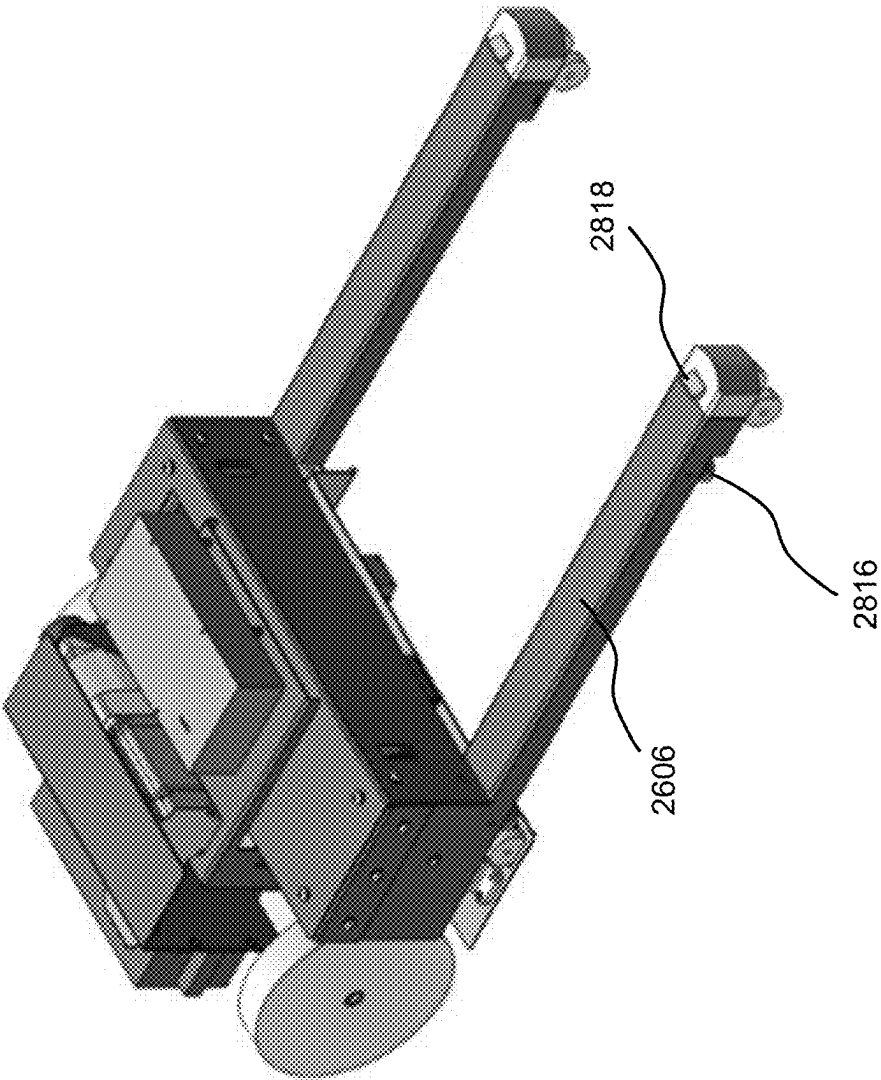


Figure 28

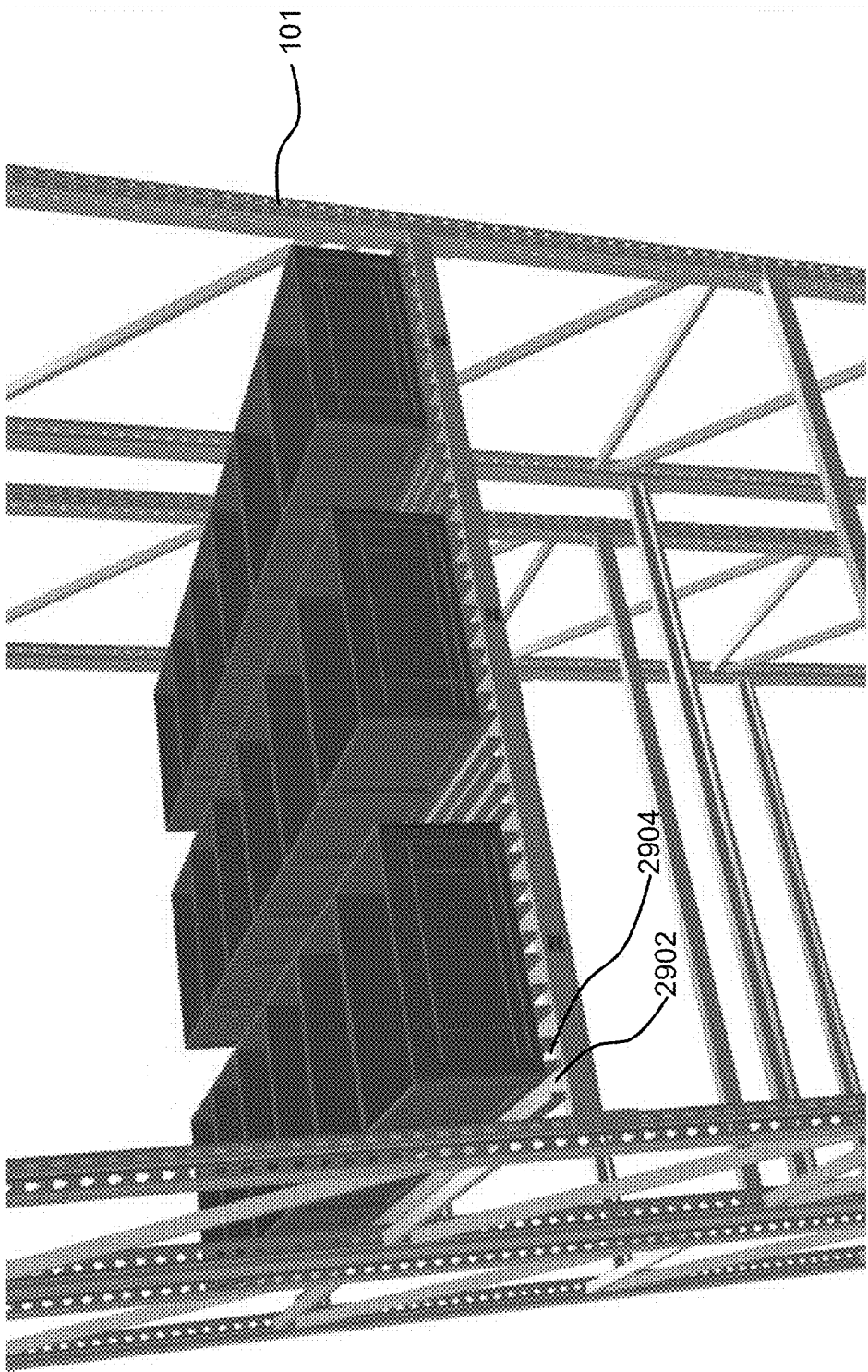


Figure 29

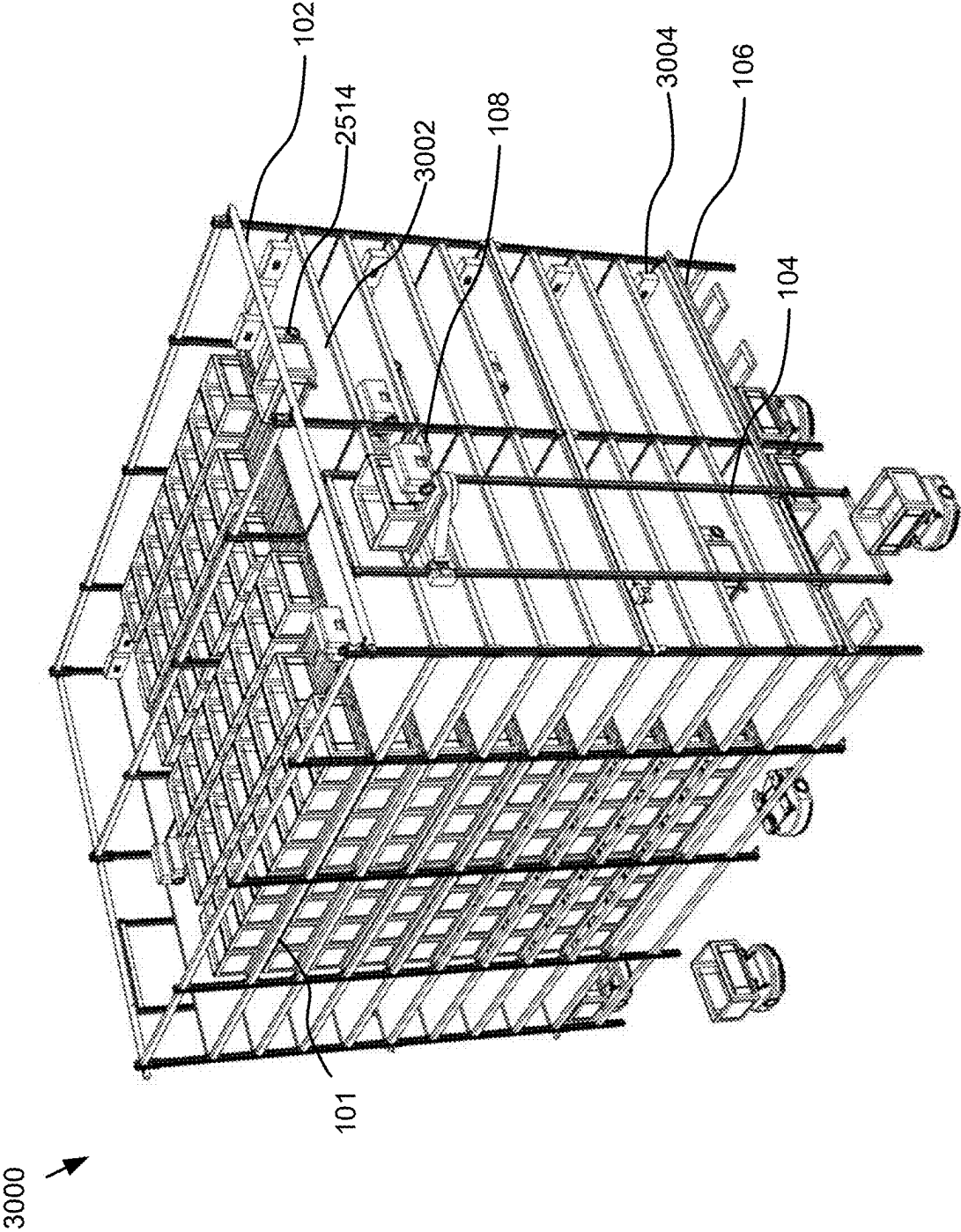


Figure 30

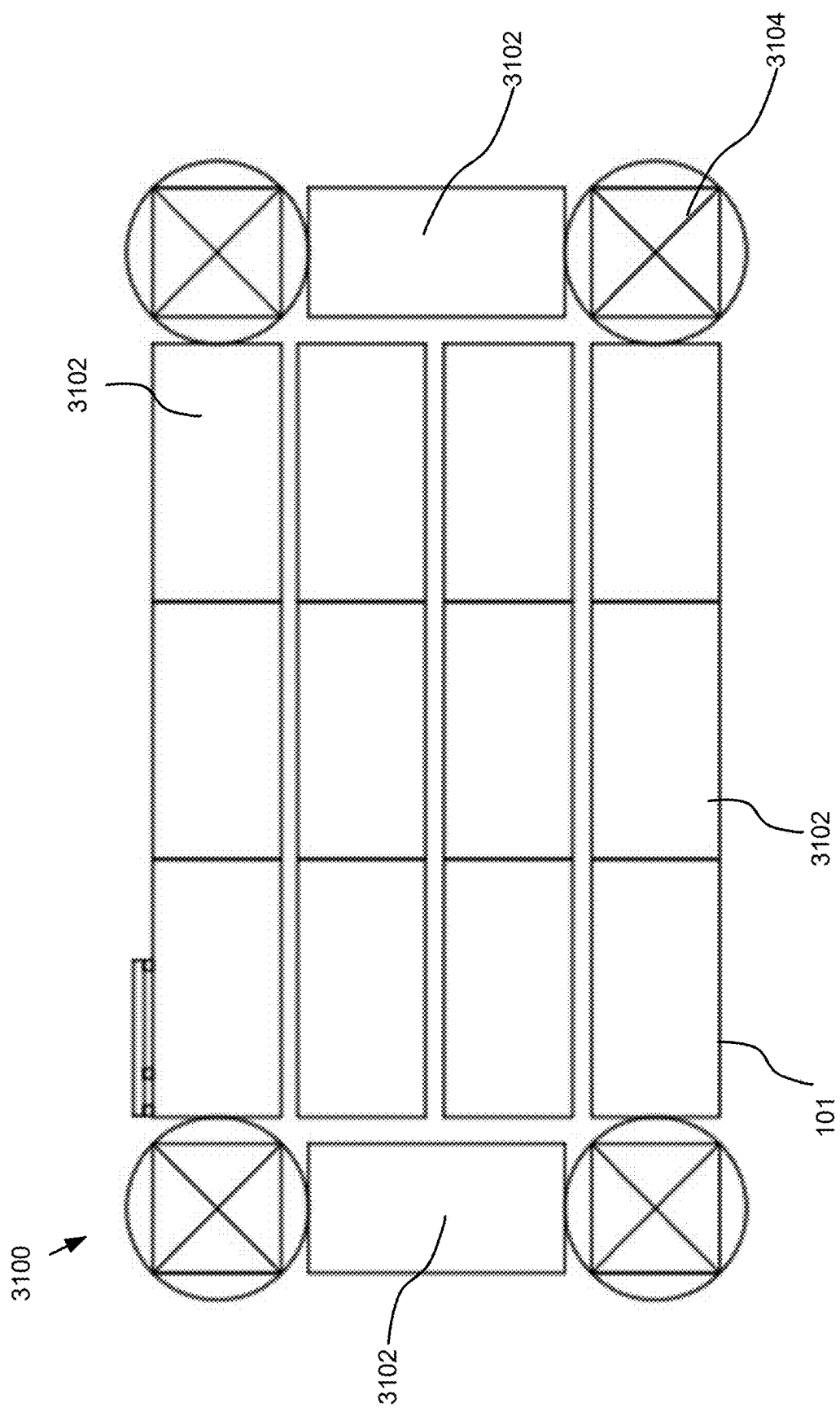


Figure 31

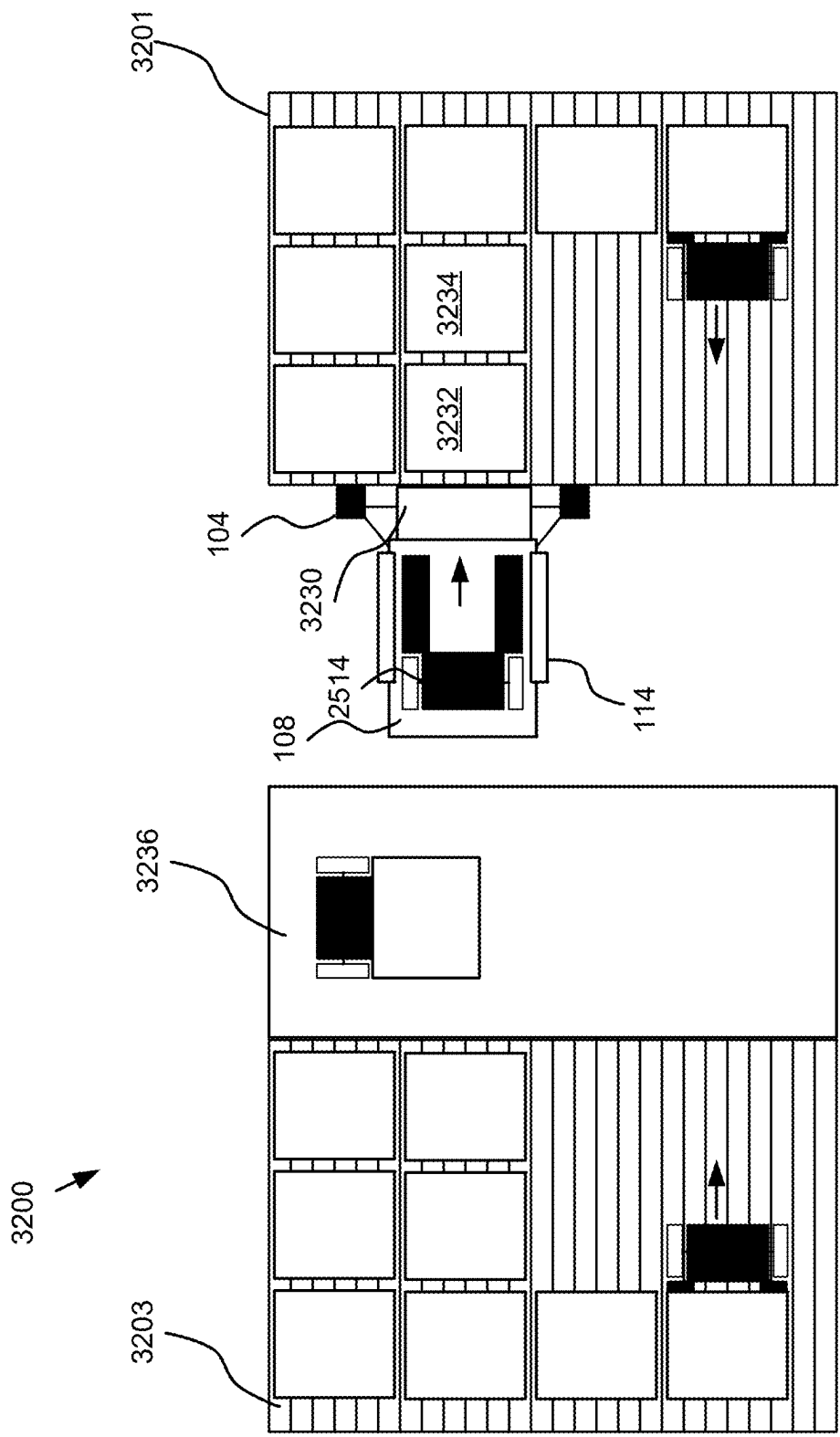


Figure 32

LOAD HANDLING SYSTEM FOR STORAGE RACKING

CROSS REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS

[0001] This application is a divisional of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 18/917,863, filed Oct. 16, 2024, which claims priority under 35 U.S.C. § 119(e) to U.S. Provisional Patent Application No. 63/590,702, filed Oct. 16, 2023 and titled “Modularized Rack Storage System” and U.S. Provisional Patent Application No. 63/563,970, filed Mar. 12, 2024 and titled “Modularized Rack Storage System”, each of which is incorporated herein by reference in its entirety.

Background

[0002] At present, the logistics industry is developing rapidly, and the degree of automation is becoming increasingly important and advanced. Coupled with the increase in the frequency of various e-commerce promotional activities, it is difficult for the current warehousing situation to remain in a relatively stable state like the traditional business era, and it is necessary to frequently adjust the warehousing scale according to the number of orders generated by e-commerce promotions. At the same time, customers' needs for warehousing are also different. Some customers are cost-oriented and willing to sacrifice some warehousing efficiency, while some customers are efficiency-oriented and willing to relax cost requirements. At the same time, due to the different storage spaces of customers, it is difficult to unify the size specifications of all storage shelves. If customized for each customer's needs, although the needs of most customers can be solved, the high cost of customization and molding are unacceptable to logistics and warehousing suppliers.

SUMMARY

[0003] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system for storage racking, the load handling system including: a horizontal guide rail system coupled with the storage racking; a vertical guide rail assembly coupled with the horizontal guide rail system, wherein the vertical guide rail assembly is configured to be moved horizontally along the horizontal guide rail system by a first motor; a load handling platform coupled with the vertical guide rail assembly, wherein the load handling platform is configured to be moved vertically along the vertical guide rail assembly by a second motor; a load transition station coupled with the storage racking, wherein a load handling device coupled with the load handling platform is configured to move a load between a location in the storage racking and the load transition station; and a ground handling device, wherein the ground handling device is configured to move the load between the load transition station and other locations in a storage facility.

[0004] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system, wherein the ground handling device includes: a body; a drive system coupled with the body, the drive system configured to move the ground handling device between locations in the storage facility; and a load interface configured to interface with the load.

[0005] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system, wherein the load interface

is configured to extend such that, in an extended position, the load interface is configured to interface with the load at the load transition station.

[0006] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system, wherein the load interface is configured to retract such that, in a retracted position, the load supported by the load interface does not interfere with other elements of the storage racking or the load handling system as the ground handling device moves throughout the storage facility.

[0007] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system, wherein the load interface is configured to extend such that, in an extended position, the load interface is configured to interface with the load at a workstation, wherein the load at the workstation is at an ergonomic height for a worker interacting with the load at the workstation.

[0008] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system, further including a workstation, wherein the ground handling device is configured to transfer the load to a lifting device of the workstation and the lifting device is configured to raise the load to an ergonomic height for a worker.

[0009] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system for storage racking, the load handling system including: a plurality of horizontal guide rails coupled with the storage racking; a vertical guide rail assembly slidably coupled with the plurality of horizontal guide rails, wherein the vertical guide rail assembly is motorized to move horizontally along the plurality of horizontal guide rails; a load handling platform slidably coupled with the vertical guide rail assembly, wherein the load handling platform is motorized to move vertically along the vertical guide rail assembly; a load transition station coupled with the storage racking; a load handling device, wherein the load handling platform is configured to deliver the load handling device within the storage racking to move a load between a location in the storage racking and the load transition station; and a ground handling device, wherein the ground handling device is configured to move the load between the load transition station and other locations in a storage facility.

[0010] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system, wherein the ground handling device includes: a load interface configured to support the load; and a drive system configured to move the ground handling device between locations in the storage facility.

[0011] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system, wherein the load interface is configured to extend from a body of the ground handling device to lift the load from the load transition station.

[0012] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system, wherein the load interface is configured to retract toward a body of the ground handling device such that, in a retracted position, the load supported by the load interface passes underneath elements of the storage racking and the load handling system as the ground handling device moves throughout the storage facility.

[0013] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system, wherein the load interface is configured to extend from and retract toward a body of the ground handling device to deposit the load at a workstation, wherein the load at the workstation is at an ergonomic height for a worker interacting with the load at the workstation.

[0014] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system, further including a workstation, wherein the ground handling device is configured to transfer the load to a lifting device of the workstation and the lifting device is configured to raise the load to an ergonomic height for a worker.

[0015] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a load handling system, wherein the load handling device includes a vehicle configured to drive from the load handling platform and manipulate the load within the storage racking.

[0016] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a method including: moving, by a load handling device, a load from a location within storage racking to a load handling platform; moving, by the load handling platform, the load to a load transition station within the storage racking, wherein the load handling platform is motorized to move vertically along a vertical guide rail assembly, the vertical guide rail assembly slidably coupled with a plurality of horizontal guide rails coupled with the storage racking, and wherein the vertical guide rail assembly is motorized to move horizontally along the plurality of horizontal guide rails; depositing, by the load handling device, the load at the load transition station; and retrieving, by a ground handling device, the load from the load transition station, wherein the ground handling device is configured to move the load between the load transition station and other locations in a storage facility.

[0017] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a method, wherein retrieving the load from the load transition station includes extending, by the ground handling device, a load interface from a body of the ground handling device to lift the load from the load transition station.

[0018] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a method, further including retracting, by the ground handling device, a load interface toward a body of the ground handling device such that, in a retracted position, the load supported by the load interface passes underneath elements of the storage racking as the ground handling device moves throughout the storage facility.

[0019] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a method, further including depositing, by the ground handling device, the load at a workstation.

[0020] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a method, wherein depositing the load at the workstation includes: extending, by the ground handling device, a load interface from a body of the ground handling device; maneuvering, by the ground handling device, the load interface under the workstation such that the load is above a pick up and drop off location of the workstation; and retracting, by the ground handling device, the load interface toward the body of the ground handling device such that the load is deposited at the pick up and drop off location, wherein the load is deposited at the workstation at an ergonomic height for a worker interacting with the load at the workstation.

[0021] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a method, further including raising, by a lifting device of the workstation, the load to an ergonomic height for a worker.

[0022] In some aspects, the techniques described herein relate to a method, wherein the load handling device includes a vehicle configured to drive from the load handling platform and manipulate the load within the storage racking.

[0023] However, this list of features and advantages is not all-inclusive and many additional features and advantages are within the scope of the present disclosure. Moreover, it should be noted that the language used in the present disclosure has been principally selected for readability and instructional purposes, and not to limit the scope of the subject matter disclosed herein.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

[0024] FIG. 1 depicts an example load handling system attached to storage racking.

[0025] FIG. 2 depicts an upper portion of an example load handling system attached to storage racking.

[0026] FIG. 3 is an end view of an upper portion of an example load handling system attached to storage racking.

[0027] FIG. 4 depicts components of an upper portion of a vertical guide rail assembly in an example load handling system.

[0028] FIGS. 5 depicts an example of an upper bracket assembly for attaching a load handling system to storage racking.

[0029] FIG. 6 is a top view of upper bracket assembly and depicts the angular adjustability of the upper bracket assembly in the horizontal direction parallel to the face of storage racking.

[0030] FIG. 7 is a side view of upper bracket assembly and depicts the angular adjustability of the upper bracket assembly in the vertical direction.

[0031] FIG. 8 depicts the linear adjustability of the upper bracket assembly in the vertical direction.

[0032] FIG. 9 depicts a lower portion of an example load handling system attached to storage racking.

[0033] FIG. 10 depicts an example of a lower bracket assembly for attaching a load handling system to storage racking.

[0034] FIG. 11 depicts another view of an example of a lower bracket assembly for attaching a load handling system to storage racking.

[0035] FIG. 12 depicts an example of a flexible motor mount for use in a load handling system.

[0036] FIG. 13 depicts an example of a flexible motor mount for use in a load handling system attached to the vertical guide rail assembly.

[0037] FIG. 14 depicts an example load handling platform and load handling device for use in a load handling system.

[0038] FIG. 15 depicts an example vertical slider assembly configured to move a load handling platform vertically along a vertical rail.

[0039] FIG. 16 is a cutaway view from the top of an example vertical slider assembly.

[0040] FIG. 17 depicts an example load handling device for use in a load handling system.

[0041] FIG. 18 depicts an overhead view of an example vertical guide rail assembly mounted between two rows of storage racking.

[0042] FIG. 19 depicts an overhead view of an example vertical guide rail assembly mounted between two rows of storage racking.

[0043] FIG. 20 depicts an overhead view of an example vertical guide rail assembly mounted between two rows of storage racking.

[0044] FIG. 21 shows an example load handling device coupled with vertical guide rail assembly and extending into storage racking from a different perspective.

[0045] FIG. 22 is a line drawing of an example workstation in a load handling system.

[0046] FIG. 23 depicts an example ground handling device for use in a load handling system.

[0047] FIG. 24 depicts an example elevated workstation with multiple pick up and drop off locations.

[0048] FIG. 25 depicts an example modularized storage system.

[0049] FIG. 26 is an illustration of an example load handling device.

[0050] FIG. 27 is a front view of an example load handling device.

[0051] FIG. 28 is a perspective view of an example load handling device.

[0052] FIG. 29 depicts an example storage rack with corrugated decking.

[0053] FIG. 30 depicts another example embodiment of a modularized storage system.

[0054] FIG. 31 depicts an overhead view of another example embodiment of a modularized storage system.

[0055] FIG. 32 is an overhead view of another embodiment of a modularized storage system.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0056] The technology described in this disclosure relates to load handling in a warehouse or similar storage environment where vertical storage racking is employed and particularly to environments where dense storage solutions are employed. As an example, the technology provides for automated and efficient retrieval and replacement of loads in the storage racking in a dense, multi-deep storage system.

[0057] FIG. 1 depicts an example load handling system 100 attached to storage racking 101. The load handling system 100 is designed to be universally compatible with a wide variety of storage racking systems. The load handling system 100 includes an upper horizontal guide rail 102, a vertical guide rail assembly 104, a lower horizontal guide rail 106, a load handling platform 108, and load handling device 114. The upper horizontal guide rail 102 is connected to the storage racking 101 by upper bracket assembly 110. The lower horizontal guide rail 106 is connected to the storage racking 101 by lower bracket assemblies 112. The upper bracket assembly 110 and lower bracket assembly 112, as described in more detail below, are designed to be adjustable in three dimensions to allow for variations in the storage racking 101 while maintaining the upper horizontal guide rail 102 and lower horizontal guide rail 106 in a straight and stable position to allow the vertical guide rail assembly 104 to travel freely along the upper horizontal guide rail 102 and the lower horizontal guide rail 106.

[0058] The vertical guide rail assembly 104 connects to, and travels horizontally along, upper horizontal guide rail 102 and lower horizontal guide rail 106. Load handling platform 108 connects to, and travels vertically along, the rails of the vertical guide rail assembly 104. The horizontal movement of the vertical guide rail assembly 104 and the vertical movement of the load handling platform 108 allows the load handling device 114 to access and manipulate loads from any position in the storage racking 101. While the loads depicted in the examples throughout the figures are totes, it should be noted that the load handling device 114 may be adapted to handle various types of loads or objects including, but not limited to, totes, trays, boxes, cartons, pallets, etc.

[0059] While the example of FIG. 1 depicts a single load handling platform 108 and load handling device 114 coupled with vertical guide rail assembly 104, it should be appreciated that each vertical guide rail assembly 104 in load handling system 100 can accommodate multiple load handling platforms and/or load handling devices. For example, storage racking may be divided into two or more vertical zones, each with one or more load handling platforms and/or load handling devices deployed to service a vertical zone. In another embodiment, a first load handling device can remove and hold a first load from storage racking so a second load handling device on the same vertical guide rail assembly can access a second load that was stored behind the first load. It should be apparent that any number of load handling platforms and/or load handling devices can be used to access loads stored deeper in the storage racking.

[0060] FIG. 2 depicts an upper portion of an example load handling system 100 attached to storage racking 101. As shown in the example of FIG. 2, upper horizontal guide rail 102 may be an I or H type beam coupled with the storage racking 101 by the upper bracket assembly 110. The vertical guide rail assembly 104 is slidably coupled with the upper horizontal guide rail 102 by trolley 202 and trolley 204 and is moved along the upper horizontal guide rail 102 by upper horizontal drive motor 206. In some embodiments, multiple horizontal drive motors may be attached to the vertical guide rail assembly 104 and move the vertical guide rail assembly 104 along the upper horizontal guide rail 102. The additional horizontal drive motors allow for the vertical guide rail assembly to more quickly move loads and/or handle heavier loads.

[0061] In the example of FIG. 2, the upper portion of the vertical guide rail assembly 104 includes a vertical guide rail mounting plates 208 which are bolted together and secure vertical rail 210 and vertical rail 212 of the vertical guide rail assembly 104 together. The other components of the upper portion of the vertical guide rail assembly 104, including, for example, upper horizontal drive motor 206, trolley 202, trolley 204, and sliding power connector 214, are also connected to vertical guide rail mounting plates 208. Sliding power connector 214 interfaces with power rail 216 and provides power to the components of the vertical guide rail assembly 104 as it moves along the upper horizontal guide rail 102.

[0062] As further shown in the example of FIG. 2, the upper bracket assembly 110 supports power rail 216 and upper gear rack 218. Upper gear rack 218 interfaces with a pinion gear (not shown) on upper horizontal drive motor 206. The rack and pinion system drives the vertical guide rail assembly 104 horizontally along upper horizontal guide rail 102.

[0063] FIG. 3 is an end view of an upper portion of an example load handling system 100 attached to storage racking 101. The example of FIG. 3 shows upper bracket assembly 110 attached to storage racking 101. The upper bracket assembly 110 supports the upper horizontal guide rail 102 via a guide rail support plate 302 and guide rail pressure plates 304. Trolley 202 of the vertical guide rail assembly 104 rests on and moves along the upper horizontal guide rail 102. As shown in example of FIG. 3, upper gear rack 218 is coupled with the guide rail support plate 302 and extends along the front of the storage racking 101 parallel to upper horizontal guide rail 102. Upper pinion gear 306 is coupled with upper horizontal drive motor 206 and engages

with the upper gear rack **218** to drive the vertical guide rail assembly **104** along the upper horizontal guide rail **102**. As shown in the example of FIG. 3, power rail **216** is coupled directly with upper bracket assembly **110** and engages with sliding power connector **214** to provide power to components of vertical guide rail assembly **104**. In other embodiments, guide rail support plate **302** is longer and power rail **216** is attached to the bottom of guide rail support plate **302**. [0064] In some embodiments, to make installation of the load handling system easier, upper horizontal guide rail **102** is installed in multiple sections. To ensure proper alignment and strength at the joints of the multi-section upper horizontal guide rail **102**, splints **308** are secured over the joints of the upper horizontal guide rail **102**. When guide rail support plate **302** is installed on a joint in the upper horizontal guide rail **102**, the guide rail support plate **302** similarly helps with the alignment and rigidity of the upper horizontal guide rail **102**.

[0065] FIG. 4 depicts components of an upper portion of a vertical guide rail assembly **104** in an example load handling system **100**. The vertical guide rail assembly **104** includes vertical guide rails along which a load handling device travels vertically in the load handling system **100**. The example of FIG. 4 depicts a vertical guide rail **402** of a vertical guide rail assembly **104**. The vertical guide rail **402** is secured to the vertical guide rail mounting plates **208** via bracket **406** and bracket **404** creating stability in all directions when a load handling device is traveling along the vertical guide rail **402**. The vertical guide rail assembly **104** includes an anti-jump roller **408** that sits underneath the upper horizontal guide rail **102** and works with the wheels of trolley **202** to keep the vertical guide rail assembly **104** from bouncing off the upper horizontal guide rail **102**. In some embodiments, anti-jump roller **408** is mounted on a pivot plate that is supported by a spring such that the anti-jump roller **408** maintains contact with the underside of the upper horizontal guide rail **102** to decrease the chance that the vertical guide rail assembly **104** comes off the upper horizontal guide rail **102**.

[0066] FIGS. 5 depicts an example of an upper bracket assembly **110** for attaching a load handling system to storage racking. The upper bracket assembly **110** includes an upper racking column adapter **502**. A column adapter portion **503** of the upper racking column adapter **502** attaches to a column of storage racking **101** and a support member **504**, extending from the column adapter portion **503** of the upper racking column adapter **502**, supports the remaining components of the upper bracket assembly **110**. To support the upper horizontal guide rail **102**, guide rail support plate **302** is suspended from pressure plates **506** bolted together and compressed around the support member **504** of upper racking column adapter **502**. Guide rail pressure plates **304** secure the upper horizontal guide rail **102** to the guide rail support plate **302**. Guide rail support plate **302** also supports a rack plate **508** which houses upper gear rack **218** and power rail **216**.

[0067] Adjustability of the upper bracket assembly is important because storage racking is rarely perfectly level, plumb, and straight. Horizontal guide rails attached to the front of storage racking with typical vertical and horizontal variations would lead to horizontal guide rails that are similarly not level, plumb, or straight and a vertical guide rail assembly traveling along such horizontal guide rails would bind and/or jump the track leading to decreased

reliability and wasted time. The techniques described herein address the deficiencies above by providing adjustability in multiple directions for upper horizontal guide rail **102** (as described with reference to FIG. 6 through FIG. 8) and lower horizontal guide rail **106** (as described with reference to FIGS. 9 through FIG. 11). This adjustability allows the upper horizontal guide rail **102** and lower horizontal guide rail **106** to be attached to storage racking **101** and run level, plumb, and straight, even if the storage racking **101** is not perfectly level, plumb, and/or straight, so that vertical guide rail assembly **104** can travel smoothly across the face of storage racking **101**.

[0068] FIG. 6 is a top view of upper bracket assembly **110** and depicts the ability to adjust the yaw of the upper bracket assembly **110** (i.e., horizontal angular adjustments left or right in the relative position between support member **504** and pressure plates **506** where the x-axis extends parallel to the face of storage racking **101** and the y-axis extends vertically). In one embodiment, pressure plates **506** allow for up to three degrees of adjustment around the support member **504** to correct for twist in the vertical posts of the storage racking **101**. In addition to the angular adjustability of upper bracket assembly **110**, pressure plates **506** can be positioned at any point along support member **504** to account for variations in depth of connection points to storage racking **101**.

[0069] FIG. 7 is a side view of upper bracket assembly **110** and depicts the ability to adjust the pitch of the upper bracket assembly **110** (i.e., vertical angular adjustments in the relative position between the distal end of support member **504** and the face of storage racking **101** where the x-axis is aligned parallel to the face of storage racking **101**). In one embodiment, column adapter portion **503** allows for up to three degrees of adjustment relative to a vertical post of storage racking **101** to account for unlevel storage racking **101**.

[0070] FIG. 8 depicts the linear adjustability of the upper bracket assembly **110** in the vertical direction and the ability to control the roll of the upper bracket assembly **110** (i.e., angular adjustments around the z-axis where the x-axis is aligned parallel to the face of storage racking **101** and the z-axis extends perpendicularly in the horizontal direction to the x-axis). While the upper racking column adapter **502** can be placed at multiple positions along a vertical post of storage racking **101**, the adjustability is somewhat limited due to the fact that bolt holes to fix the upper racking column adapter **502** are limited and at fixed intervals. To increase the vertical adjustability, the suspension bolts **802** that couple the guide rail support plate **302** with pressure plates **506** include additional threading so that fine adjustments to the vertical position of guide rail support plate **302** can be made so that upper horizontal guide rail **102** is level. Similarly, the vertical adjustability of suspension bolts **802** allow for adjustment in the roll of guide rail support plate **302** (e.g., by raising or lowering a pair of suspension bolts **802** on either side of support member **504**).

[0071] FIG. 9 depicts a lower portion of an example load handling system **100** attached to storage racking **101**. As depicted in the example of FIG. 9, lower horizontal guide rail **106** may be a U or L shaped track in which guide wheels of the vertical guide rail assembly **104** can slidably connect with lower horizontal guide rail **106**. Lower horizontal guide rail **106** connects with the storage racking **101** by lower bracket assembly **112**.

[0072] In some embodiments a lower horizontal drive motor 902 works in tandem with upper horizontal drive motor 206 to move vertical guide rail assembly 104 along the upper horizontal guide rail 102 and lower horizontal guide rail 106. In some embodiments, multiple lower horizontal drive motors may be attached to the vertical guide rail assembly 104 and move the vertical guide rail assembly 104 along the lower horizontal guide rail 106. The additional horizontal drive motors allow for the vertical guide rail assembly 104 to more quickly move loads and/or handle heavier loads. In one embodiment, lower horizontal drive motor 902 may include a lower pinion gear (not shown) that engages with a lower gear rack 904 to drive vertical guide rail assembly 104 along lower horizontal guide rail 106.

[0073] FIG. 10 depicts an example of a lower bracket assembly 112 for attaching a load handling system 100 to storage racking 101. In one embodiment, lower bracket assembly 112 includes a lower racking column adapter 1004 and a lower horizontal rail support 1002. As shown in the example of FIG. 10, lower racking column adapter 1004 attaches to columns of storage racking 101 and lower horizontal rail support 1002 attaches to one end of lower racking column adapter 1004. As described herein, adjustability of lower bracket assembly 112 allows lower horizontal guide rail 106 to be installed level, straight, and plumb with the upper horizontal guide rail, which allows the vertical guide rail assembly 104 to traverse the upper horizontal guide rail and lower horizontal guide rail smoothly without binding or jumping.

[0074] FIG. 11 depicts another view of an example of a lower bracket assembly 112 for attaching a load handling system 100 to storage racking 101. As can be seen in the examples of FIG. 10 and FIG. 11, lower racking column adapter 1004 includes a plurality of connection point holes 1102 that allow lower racking column adapter 1004 to be connected at various positions relative to the front of storage racking 101 so that lower horizontal guide rail 106 is straight and vertical guide rail assembly 104, when attached to lower horizontal guide rail 106 and the upper horizontal guide rail, is plumb. Lower horizontal rail support 1002 provides additional vertical adjustability so that lower horizontal guide rail 106 is level when installed on storage racking 101. In some embodiments, mounting slots 1104 in lower horizontal rail support 1002 and mounting slots 1106 in lower racking column adapter 1004 allow the lower horizontal rail support 1002 to be installed at various heights and angles relative to lower racking column adapter 1004 so that lower horizontal guide rail 106 can be installed level, plumb, and straight.

[0075] As described herein, existing storage racking may have defects due to wear and/or collision during installation or normal use. These defects create an imperfect foundation for the installation of horizontal guide rails used by the vertical guide rail assembly and leads to imperfect horizontal and/or vertical installation of the horizontal guide rails that the vertical guide rail assembly must cross. These imperfections include horizontal and vertical bending and/or deviation of the horizontal guide rails. When there is a large variation in the deviation between horizontal guide rails and pinion racks, a pinion gear on a fixed motor system engaging with the gear rack cannot accommodate the difference resulting in the vertical guide rail assembly getting stuck on the horizontal guide rails and unable to run.

[0076] FIG. 12 depicts an example of a flexible motor mount 1200 for use in a load handling system 100 to address the challenges described above. The flexible motor mount 1200 includes upper and lower limit guide wheels 1202 configured to keep the pinion gear 1204 aligned vertically with the gear rack. Front and rear limit guide wheels 1206 are configured to keep the pinion gear 1204 in contact with the gear rack. To minimize impact of variation in the horizontal and vertical position of the guide rails the flexible motor mount 1200 includes a compression spring assembly 1208 coupling motor mount 1210 with vertical guide rail assembly mount 1212. The flexible motor mount 1200 thus allows the vertical guide rail assembly to smoothly traverse storage racking even if there are variations in the guide rails.

[0077] FIG. 13 depicts an example of another embodiment of a flexible motor mount 1300 for use in a load handling system 100 to address the challenges described above. Flexible motor mount 1300 includes front and rear limit guide wheels 1302 which are configured to keep the pinion gear 1308 in contact with the gear rack. To further minimize impact of variation in the horizontal and vertical position of the guide rails the flexible motor mount 1300 includes a first compression spring assembly 1304 and a second compression spring assembly 1306 coupling motor mount 1310 with a vertical guide rail assembly. First compression spring assembly 1304 provides horizontal flexibility and second compression spring assembly 1306 provides vertical flexibility for flexible motor mount 1300 and allows the vertical guide rail assembly to smoothly traverse storage racking even if there are variations in the guide rails.

[0078] FIG. 14 depicts an example load handling platform 108 and load handling device 114 for use in a load handling system 100. Load handling platform 108 is slidably coupled with vertical rail 210 via vertical slider assembly 1402, vertical rail 212, and a second vertical slider assembly hidden from view in the example of FIG. 14. The vertical slider assemblies include motors (not shown in the example of FIG. 14) configured to move load handling platform 108 vertically along vertical rail 210 and vertical rail 212 and position load handling device 114 to manipulate loads (e.g., place, retrieve, move, etc.), such as tote 1404, stored on storage racking 101. To aid in manipulating loads, load handling device 114 includes retractable fingers 1406 which raise or lower to engage with a load being handled, as described in more detail elsewhere herein.

[0079] FIG. 15 depicts an example vertical slider assembly 1402 configured to move a load handling platform 108 vertically along vertical rail 210. The components of vertical slider assembly 1402 are contained within or attached to assembly housing 1514. Vertical drive motor 1502 is coupled with assembly housing 1514 and drives pinion gear 1506 which interfaces with gear rack 1504 to move 1402 and the attached load handling platform vertically along vertical rail 210. Front limit guide wheel 1508 and 1510, side limit guide wheel 1512 and 1516, and rear limit guide wheels (not shown in the example of FIG. 15) maintain the pinion gear 1506 in contact with gear rack 1504.

[0080] FIG. 16 is a cutaway view from the top of an example vertical slider assembly 1402. The example of FIG. 16 shows the profile of vertical rail 210 and how the components of vertical slider assembly 1402 engage with vertical rail 210 to move vertically along vertical rail 210. Front limit guide wheel 1508 and 1510 roll along a front side of vertical rail 210 and rear limit guide wheel 1602 and 1604

roll along the rear side of a limit guide wheel flange of the vertical rail while side limit guide wheel **1512** and **1606** roll along opposite sides of vertical rail **210** to slidably couple vertical slider assembly **1402** with vertical rail **210** while maintaining pinion gear **1506** in contact with gear rack **1504**.

[0081] FIG. **17** depicts an example load handling device **114** for use in a load handling system **100**. In the example of FIG. **17**, load handling device **114** includes a body **1702** and fork **1704** and **1706**. Fork **1704** and **1706** include a plurality of fingers, such as finger **1708**, **1710**, **1712**, **1714**, **1716**, **1718**, **1720**, and **1722**. The fingers, all shown in a lowered position in the example of FIG. **17**, are configured to raise and lower in different configurations to manipulate a load. Manipulation of a load may include retrieving a load from storage racking or a pick-up and drop-off location and pulling it onto body **1702** or pushing a load from body **1702** onto the storage racking or a pick-up and drop-off location. In the embodiment shown in FIG. **17**, fork **1704** and **1706** are designed to reach loads that are stacked more than one layer deep on storage racking, as described with reference to FIGS. **18-20** below. In some embodiments, either one or both of fork **1704** and **1706**, in addition to extending either direction to manipulate loads on either side of load handling device **114**, may shift laterally along body **1702** to accommodate loads of varying width.

[0082] While the horizontal and vertical guide rails can be installed level, plumb, and straight according to the techniques described herein to optimize movement of load handling device **114** along storage racking **101**, variations in storage racking can lead to items on the storage racking shelves being located at various distances from load handling platform **108**. If those distances are not accounted for by load handling device **114**, attempts to retrieve a load from storage racking **101** may fail because the distance fork **1704** and **1706** extends could either be too short or too far to accurately retrieve the load. In one embodiment, to account for these variations in distance, load handling system **100** can measure the distance to each object with location information so that load handling device **114** can accurately retrieve the object. In one embodiment, each object stored on storage racking **101** may be marked with a barcode or some other indicator that can be read by a camera or other reader on load handling platform **108** or load handling device **114** so that a distance can be determined based on the barcode.

[0083] FIGS. **18-20** depict an example process for manipulating loads on storage racking **101** by load handling device **114**. FIG. **18** depicts an overhead view of vertical guide rail assembly **104** mounted between two rows of storage racking **101**. According to the techniques described herein, when mounted to one of the rows of storage racking on horizontal and vertical guide rails, load handling device **114** can access any position along either side of storage racking. As shown in the example of FIG. **18**, load handling device **114** is extending fork **1704** and **1706** in the direction away from where vertical guide rail assembly **104** is attached to storage racking **101**. When manipulating a load, such as tote **1802**, load handling device **114** lowers finger **1708**, **1712**, **1716**, and **1720** to encompass the corners of tote **1802** and retrieve or store the tote **1802** on storage racking **101**. It should be appreciated, particularly in light of the following examples, that various combinations of fingers and fork depths can be used to access any position in storage racking.

[0084] FIG. **19** depicts an overhead view of vertical guide rail assembly **104** mounted between two rows of storage racking **101**. As shown in the example of FIG. **19**, load handling device **114** is extending fork **1704** and **1706** in the direction toward where vertical guide rail assembly **104** is attached to storage racking **101**. When manipulating a load, such as tote **1902**, load handling device **114** lowers finger **1710**, **1714**, **1718**, and **1722** to encompass the corners of tote **1902** and retrieve or store the tote **1902** from or to storage racking **101**.

[0085] Increasing the stroke length of fork **1704** and **1706** and using a different combination of fingers allows load handling device **114** to reach deeper into storage racking **101** and manipulate loads. Increasing the reach depth allows for fewer load handling systems to be deployed in a system than if each load handling device could only reach the first row of objects in storage racking. FIG. **20** depicts an overhead view of vertical guide rail assembly **104** mounted between two rows of storage racking **101**. As shown in the example of FIG. **20**, load handling device **114** is extending fork **1704** and **1706** beyond the first row of objects and accessing an object, for example tote **2002**, in the second row. To retrieve or store tote **2002** load handling device **114** lowers finger **1708**, **1712**, **1716**, and **1720** to encompass the corners of tote **2002** and retrieve or store the tote **2002** from or to storage racking **101**. With the configuration shown in the example of FIG. **20**, load handling device **114** can retrieve tote **2002** and **2004** simultaneously or individually.

[0086] FIG. **21** shows an example load handling device **114** coupled with vertical guide rail assembly **104** and extending into storage racking **101** from a different perspective.

[0087] In some embodiments, load handling system **100** may be part of a larger fulfillment environment where load handling system **100** delivers a load to human workers located at workstations throughout the facility. In one embodiment, a workstation may be incorporated into storage racking **101**. FIG. **22** depicts an example workstation integrated into storage racking **101**. In the example of FIG. **22**, a workstation may include one or more racks installed at an angle, such as rack **2204**. The angled rack provides easier access to the contents of a tote, such as tote **2206**, for a worker located at the workstation. A load handling system **100** as described herein may be attached to the opposite side of storage racking **101** from the work station. In the example of FIG. **22**, load handling device **114** of load handling system **100** traverses storage racking **101** and picks up and drops off totes to the workstation.

[0088] In some embodiments, workstations are located remotely from storage racking and loads, such as totes, must be moved from storage racking to a workstation. Various solutions, including automated ground vehicles, have been implemented to transport loads between storage racking and workstations. FIG. **23** depicts an example ground handling device, such as automated ground vehicle **2300**, for use as part of load handling system **100**. In a system such as load handling system **100** where automated ground vehicle **2300** may be interacting with loads at varying heights it would be beneficial to have an automated ground vehicle that has an adjustable load interface **2302**. Lifting mechanism **2304** adjusts the height of load interface **2302** depending on the context of the interaction by automated ground vehicle **2300**. For example, to allow for easier maneuverability of automated ground vehicle **2300** throughout storage racking, pick up and drop off locations, as well as shelves and vertical

guide rail assembly **104** may be elevated off of the floor. To retrieve a load, automated ground vehicle **2300** raises adjustable load interface **2302** and lifts the load off of an elevated pick up and drop off location in storage racking. Once the load has been retrieved, adjustable load interface **2302** is retracted and automated ground vehicle **2300** can navigate throughout the facility without interfering with overhead objects.

[0089] FIG. 24, depicts an example elevated workstation **2400** with multiple pick up and drop off locations **2402**. Automated ground vehicle **2300** transfers a load between storage racking and elevated workstation **2400**. As depicted in the example of FIG. 24, automated ground vehicle **2300** is retrieving tote **2404** from pick up and drop off location **2402**. Automated ground vehicle **2300** drives under pick up and drop off location **2402** and raises adjustable load interface **2302** to lift tote **2404** off of elevated workstation **2400**. After lifting tote **2404**, automated ground vehicle **2300** moves away and can lower adjustable load interface **2302** to avoid interference with other objects in the facility.

[0090] In some embodiments, instead of automated ground vehicle **2300** using adjustable load interface **2302** to lift tote **2404** to an ergonomic height, a component of the pick up and drop off location **2402** may be configured to raise and lower the tote. For example, in one embodiment, automated ground vehicle **2300** may be configured to navigate on a closed loop to a load transition station where load handling device **114** deposits a load on automated ground vehicle **2300**. Automated ground vehicle **2300** carries the load on the closed loop to a workstation where a lifting platform raises the load off of automated ground vehicle **2300** up to an ergonomic height for a worker at the workstation. In some embodiments, the workstation may include a conveyor to move one or more loads from the lifting platform to a worker and from the worker to a lowering platform where the lowering platform places the load on an automated ground vehicle **2300** to return on the closed loop to a transition station where load handling device **114** retrieves the load from automated ground vehicle **2300**.

[0091] FIG. 25 depicts a modularized storage system **2500**, which can adapt to the needs and storage space constraints of various environments, while maintaining a reasonable production cost. To achieve low-cost flexibility, the modularized storage system **2500** in the example of FIG. 25 utilizes standard storage racking **101** but may be configured to work with any number of storage racking configurations. Modularized storage system **2500** includes a load handling system **100** as described herein and one embodiment is depicted in the example of FIG. 25. Horizontal guide rails, such as upper horizontal guide rail **102** and **106**, are attached to the storage racking **101**. In the example of FIG. 25, vertical guide rail assembly **104** includes load handling platform **108** and load handling device **2514**. In the example of FIG. 25, load handling device **2514** is configured to drive off of the load handling platform **108** and retrieve objects, such as tote **2516**, from storage racking **101**.

[0092] As described herein, load handling platform **108** is configured to move vertically along vertical guide rail assembly **104** and deliver the load handling device **2514** to any shelf of the storage racking **101**. Similarly, the vertical guide rail assembly **104** is configured to move horizontally along the storage racking **101** to deliver load handling device **2514** to any point in storage racking **101**. In some embodiments, the load handling platform **108** may further

include imaging or other sensing devices to orient itself and deliver load handling device **2514** to the appropriate location on the storage racking **101**.

[0093] As shown in the example of FIG. 25, the modularized storage system **2500** includes load transition stations, such as load transition station **1522**. The load transition stations allow for the modularized storage system **2500** to use a multi-deep dense storage system (i.e., multiple objects can be stored on a single row). Load handling device **2514** may use the load transition station **1522** to hold an object while returning to retrieve the next object in a row. Additionally, the load transition station **1522** may be used as a pick-up and drop-off area for automated ground vehicles, such as automated ground vehicle **2300**, to retrieve objects and transport them to other areas of the storage facility for further processing. In some embodiments, automated ground vehicle **2300** may be equipped with wireless charging equipment that interacts with a wireless charging station when stopped at a load transition station.

[0094] FIG. 26 is an illustration of an example load handling device **2514**. The load handling device **2514** may include drive wheel **2602** and **2604**. The drive wheels allow the load handling device **2514** to detach from load handling platform **108** and navigate the storage rack **101** independently of the vertical guide rail assembly **104**. In some embodiments, drive wheels **2602** and **2604** can operate independently allowing the load handling device **2514** to travel omnidirectionally.

[0095] As shown in the example of FIG. 26, the Load handling device **114** may include one or more forks **2606** that are configured to handle objects. In some embodiments, the forks **2606** are configured to handle multiple objects at once, effectively reducing the number of trips load handling device **2514** needs to make to get to deeper objects in the multi-deep storage system. The forks **2606** may further include one or more guide wheels **2608** that are configured to support the forks and assist the load handling device **2514** in navigating the storage rack **101**. For example, the guide wheels **2608** and the drive wheels **2602** and **2604** may be configured to interface with tracks in corrugated decking of the storage rack **101** that guide the load handling device **2514** in and out of the storage rack **101**. While the example of FIG. 26 depicts load handling device **2514** having two forks, it should be understood that any number of forks may be present on a load handling device **2514** to accommodate different types of loads.

[0096] FIG. 27 is a front view of an example load handling device **2514**. Load handling device **2514** includes sensors to help navigate a storage rack. For example, load handling device **2514** may include object detection sensor **2710** and **2712**. Object detection sensor **2710** and **2712** may be configured to detect proximity to and position of objects with which load handling device **2514** may interact. In one embodiment, object detection sensors **2710** and **2712** may determine if an object is in a suitable position for load handling device **2514** to lift and retrieve. In some embodiments, object detection sensor **2710** and **2712** can detect the beginning and end of an object to identify whether the object is positioned within the lifting zone of load handling device **2514**.

[0097] Load handling device **2514** may further include one or more device position sensors, such as device position sensor **2714**. Device position sensor **2714** may be configured to determine the position of load handling device **2514**

within a storage rack. For example, device position sensor **2714** may be configured to count marks, holes, or other position identifying features on the corrugated decking or work bays of a storage rack to determine its position. Additionally, information from device position sensors and motor encoders for the motors operating drive wheel **2602** and **2604** may be combined to better determine a position of load handling device **2514**. In some embodiments, storage racking may include reference points (e.g., the front of the rack, a specific mark or identifier within a rack) to signify a position within the rack to load handling device **2514**.

[0098] FIG. 28 is another view of an example load handling device **2514**. As seen in the example of FIG. 26, the forks **2606** of load handling device **2514** may include one or more spring loaded idler wheels **2816** to maintain the position of load handling device **2514** in the tracks of the corrugated decking. Additionally, the forks of load handling device **2514** may include object retention devices, such as object retention device **2818**, that provide a retention mechanism for objects being transported by load handling device **2514**.

[0099] FIG. 29 illustrates an example storage rack **101** with corrugated decking **2902**. It should be noted that the modularized storage system described herein is configured to work with conventional storage racking systems and there is no need for custom rack storage, thus reducing cost to the storage facility. In some embodiments, as shown in the example of FIG. 29, the corrugated decking may be realized by installing a plurality of tracks, such as track **2902**, at specified intervals to accommodate the wheels of a handling vehicle. Additionally, using tracks to create the corrugated decking allows for spaces, such as space **2904**, between the tracks. These spaces allow vision systems included in the load handling platform **108** and/or the load handling device **2514** to identify objects stored within storage racking **101**. For example, QR codes, barcodes, or other identifying marks on objects in storage racking **101** may be aligned with the spaces such that vision systems of the load handling platform **108** and/or load handling device **2514** may identify the objects. In other embodiments, load handling platform **108** and/or load handling device **2514** may use image processing to identify objects and their locations without identifying marks.

[0100] FIG. 30 illustrates another embodiment of a modularized storage system **3000**. In the example of FIG. 30, the modularized storage system **3000** includes work bays, such as work bay **3002**, where multiple load handling devices, such as load handling device **2514**, may work to stage and retrieve objects from storage racking **101**. The addition of work bays in the modularized storage system **3000** allows the handling vehicles to shuffle objects within storage racking **101** without having to utilize the load handling platform **108** to navigate off of the current level of storage racking **101** to access objects deeper in storage racking **101**. This configuration provides additional efficiencies in accessing objects in storage racking **101**. As shown in the example of FIG. 30, upper horizontal guide rail **102** and lower horizontal guide rail **106** may be mounted on the storage rack **101** adjacent to the work bays such that vertical guide rail assembly **104** and load handling platform **108** may access the work bays. Work bays may include charging stations, such as charging station **3004**, where load handling device **2514** can charge onboard batteries.

[0101] FIG. 31 is an overhead view of another embodiment of a modularized storage system **3100**. In the example of FIG. 31, work bays **3102** may be located on all sides of storage racking **101** and load handling devices can access objects from any direction within the storage rack. In one embodiment, horizontal and vertical rails with vehicle platforms may be installed on one or more sides of storage racking **101**. However, it may be cost prohibitive to have multiple vehicle platforms servicing a single storage cube. In other embodiments, horizontal guide rails may be installed on all sides of the storage rack and detachable, rotating corner sections **3104** provide for transitions of the vertical guide rail assembly from side to side of the storage rack.

[0102] FIG. 32 is an overhead view of another embodiment of a modularized storage system **3200**. In the example of FIG. 32, multiple storage racks, for example storage rack **3201** and **3203**, may be serviced by a single load handling platform **108** and vertical guide rail assembly **104** coupled with storage rack **3201**. Load handling platform **108** may include a retractable ramp **3230** configured to allow load handling device **2514** to drive from load handling platform **108** onto a storage rack. While a single retractable ramp **3230** is shown in the example of FIG. 32, it should be understood that a split platform (one for each wheel of load handling device **2514**) may be employed. With the retractable ramp **3230** retracted, load handling platform **108** is free to rotate in all directions to access storage rack **3203**. For example, load handling platform **108** may rotate **180** degrees and extend retractable ramp **3230** so that load handling device **2514** may access storage rack **3203**.

[0103] In some embodiments, load handling platform **108** may include a load handling device **114**, such as the handling device described above, in addition to being a platform to carry load handling device **2514**. Load handling device **114** may be configured to manipulate objects, such as objects **3232** and **3234**, independent of load handling device **2514**.

[0104] As described above storage racks may include a work bay, such as work bay **3236**, to allow a handling vehicle to move objects around the storage rack. The handling vehicles described herein are configured to travel on a flat surface and the wheels can operate independently so that the handling vehicle can travel in any direction in a work bay as well as navigate in the tracks of the corrugated decking as described above.

[0105] The foregoing description, for purpose of explanation, has been described with reference to various embodiments and examples. However, the illustrative discussions above are not intended to be exhaustive or to limit the invention to the precise forms disclosed. Many modifications and variations are possible in view of the above teachings. The various embodiments and examples were chosen and described in order to best explain the principles of the invention and its practical applications, to thereby enable others skilled in the art to utilize the innovative technology with various modifications as may be suited to the particular use contemplated. For instance, it should be understood that the technology described herein can be practiced without these specific details in some cases. Further, various systems, devices, and structures are shown in block diagram form in order to avoid obscuring the description. For instance, various implementations are described as having particular hardware, software, and user interfaces.

[0106] In some instances, various implementations may be presented herein in terms of algorithms and symbolic representations of operations on data bits within a computer memory. An algorithm is here, and generally, conceived to be a self-consistent set of operations leading to a desired result. The operations are those requiring physical manipulations of physical quantities. Usually, though not necessarily, these quantities take the form of electrical or magnetic signals capable of being stored, transferred, combined, compared, and otherwise manipulated. It has proven convenient at times, principally for reasons of common usage, to refer to these signals as bits, values, elements, symbols, characters, terms, numbers, or the like.

[0107] It should be borne in mind, however, that all of these and similar terms are to be associated with the appropriate physical quantities and are merely convenient labels applied to these quantities. Unless specifically stated otherwise as apparent from the following discussion, it is appreciated that throughout this disclosure, discussions utilizing terms such as “processing,” “computing,” “calculating,” “determining,” “displaying,” or the like, refer to the action and methods of a computer system that manipulates and transforms data represented as physical (electronic) quantities within the computer system’s registers and memories into other data similarly represented as physical quantities within the computer system memories or registers or other such information storage, transmission or display devices.

[0108] A data processing system suitable for storing and/or executing program code, such as the computing system and/or devices discussed herein, may include at least one processor coupled directly or indirectly to memory elements through a system bus. The memory elements can include local memory employed during actual execution of the program code, bulk storage, and cache memories that provide temporary storage of at least some program code in order to reduce the number of times code must be retrieved from bulk storage during execution. Input or I/O devices can be coupled to the system either directly or through intervening I/O controllers. The data processing system may include an apparatus may be specially constructed for the required purposes, or it may comprise a general-purpose computer selectively activated or reconfigured by a computer program stored in the computer.

[0109] The foregoing description has been presented for the purposes of illustration and description. It is not intended to be exhaustive or to limit the specification to the precise form disclosed. Many modifications and variations are possible in light of the above teaching. It is intended that the scope of the disclosure be limited not by this detailed description, but rather by the claims of this application. As will be understood by those familiar with the art, the specification may be embodied in other specific forms without departing from the spirit or essential characteristics thereof. Likewise, the particular naming and division of the modules, routines, features, attributes, methodologies and other aspects may not be mandatory or significant, and the mechanisms that implement the specification or its features may have different names, divisions, and/or formats.

[0110] Furthermore, the modules, routines, features, attributes, methodologies and other aspects of the disclosure can be implemented as software, hardware, firmware, or any combination of the foregoing. The technology can also take the form of a computer program product accessible from a computer-usable or computer-readable medium providing

program code for use by or in connection with a computer or any instruction execution system. Wherever a component, an example of which is a module or engine, of the specification is implemented as software, the component can be implemented as a standalone program, as part of a larger program, as a plurality of separate programs, as a statically or dynamically linked library, as a kernel loadable module, as firmware, as resident software, as microcode, as a device driver, and/or in every and any other way known now or in the future. Additionally, the disclosure is in no way limited to implementation in any specific programming language, or for any specific operating system or environment. Accordingly, the disclosure is intended to be illustrative, but not limiting, of the scope of the subject matter set forth in the following claims.

What is claimed is:

1. A load handling system for storage racking, the load handling system comprising:
 - a horizontal guide rail system coupled with the storage racking;
 - a vertical guide rail assembly coupled with the horizontal guide rail system, wherein the vertical guide rail assembly is configured to be moved horizontally along the horizontal guide rail system by a first motor;
 - a load handling platform coupled with the vertical guide rail assembly, wherein the load handling platform is configured to be moved vertically along the vertical guide rail assembly by a second motor;
 - a load transition station coupled with the storage racking, wherein a load handling device coupled with the load handling platform is configured to move a load between a location in the storage racking and the load transition station; and
 - a ground handling device, wherein the ground handling device is configured to move the load between the load transition station and other locations in a storage facility.
2. The load handling system of claim 1, wherein the ground handling device comprises:
 - a body;
 - a drive system coupled with the body, the drive system configured to move the ground handling device between locations in the storage facility; and
 - a load interface configured to interface with the load.
3. The load handling system of claim 2, wherein the load interface is configured to extend such that, in an extended position, the load interface is configured to interface with the load at the load transition station.
4. The load handling system of claim 2, wherein the load interface is configured to retract such that, in a retracted position, the load supported by the load interface does not interfere with other elements of the storage racking or the load handling system as the ground handling device moves throughout the storage facility.
5. The load handling system of claim 2, wherein the load interface is configured to extend such that, in an extended position, the load interface is configured to interface with the load at a workstation, wherein the load at the workstation is at an ergonomic height for a worker interacting with the load at the workstation.
6. The load handling system of claim 1, further comprising a workstation, wherein the ground handling device is configured to transfer the load to a lifting device of the

workstation and the lifting device is configured to raise the load to an ergonomic height for a worker.

7. A load handling system for storage racking, the load handling system comprising:

- a plurality of horizontal guide rails coupled with the storage racking;
- a vertical guide rail assembly slidably coupled with the plurality of horizontal guide rails, wherein the vertical guide rail assembly is motorized to move horizontally along the plurality of horizontal guide rails;
- a load handling platform slidably coupled with the vertical guide rail assembly, wherein the load handling platform is motorized to move vertically along the vertical guide rail assembly;
- a load transition station coupled with the storage racking;
- a load handling device, wherein the load handling platform is configured to deliver the load handling device within the storage racking to move a load between a location in the storage racking and the load transition station; and
- a ground handling device, wherein the ground handling device is configured to move the load between the load transition station and other locations in a storage facility.

8. The load handling system of claim 7, wherein the ground handling device comprises:

- a load interface configured to support the load; and
- a drive system configured to move the ground handling device between locations in the storage facility.

9. The load handling system of claim 8, wherein the load interface is configured to extend from a body of the ground handling device to lift the load from the load transition station.

10. The load handling system of claim 8, wherein the load interface is configured to retract toward a body of the ground handling device such that, in a retracted position, the load supported by the load interface passes underneath elements of the storage racking and the load handling system as the ground handling device moves throughout the storage facility.

11. The load handling system of claim 8, wherein the load interface is configured to extend from and retract toward a body of the ground handling device to deposit the load at a workstation, wherein the load at the workstation is at an ergonomic height for a worker interacting with the load at the workstation.

12. The load handling system of claim 7, further comprising a workstation, wherein the ground handling device is configured to transfer the load to a lifting device of the workstation and the lifting device is configured to raise the load to an ergonomic height for a worker.

13. The load handling system of claim 7, wherein the load handling device comprises a vehicle configured to drive from the load handling platform and manipulate the load within the storage racking.

14. A method comprising:

- moving, by a load handling device, a load from a location within storage racking to a load handling platform;
- moving, by the load handling platform, the load to a load transition station within the storage racking, wherein the load handling platform is motorized to move vertically along a vertical guide rail assembly, the vertical guide rail assembly slidably coupled with a plurality of horizontal guide rails coupled with the storage racking, and wherein the vertical guide rail assembly is motorized to move horizontally along the plurality of horizontal guide rails;
- depositing, by the load handling device, the load at the load transition station; and
- retrieving, by a ground handling device, the load from the load transition station, wherein the ground handling device is configured to move the load between the load transition station and other locations in a storage facility.

15. The method of claim 14, wherein retrieving the load from the load transition station comprises extending, by the ground handling device, a load interface from a body of the ground handling device to lift the load from the load transition station.

16. The method of claim 14, further comprising retracting, by the ground handling device, a load interface toward a body of the ground handling device such that, in a retracted position, the load supported by the load interface passes underneath elements of the storage racking as the ground handling device moves throughout the storage facility.

17. The method of claim 14, further comprising depositing, by the ground handling device, the load at a workstation.

18. The method of claim 17, wherein depositing the load at the workstation comprises:

- extending, by the ground handling device, a load interface from a body of the ground handling device;
- maneuvering, by the ground handling device, the load interface under the workstation such that the load is above a pick up and drop off location of the workstation; and
- retracting, by the ground handling device, the load interface toward the body of the ground handling device such that the load is deposited at the pick up and drop off location, wherein the load is deposited at the workstation at an ergonomic height for a worker interacting with the load at the workstation.

19. The method of claim 17, further comprising raising, by a lifting device of the workstation, the load to an ergonomic height for a worker.

20. The method of claim 14, wherein the load handling device comprises a vehicle configured to drive from the load handling platform and manipulate the load within the storage racking.

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